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Gray Divorce

Coming Back Together (or Apart) at 55+

What to Do When 30+ Years of Marriage Stops Working — and the Stakes Are Higher Than They Were at 30

A 4-Phase Framework for the Decision, the Conversation, and the New Life

by Sanjay Shharma

Author of The Care Collection

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Copyright Page

Gray Divorce: Coming Back Together (or Apart) at 55+

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This is a work of nonfiction. All names, identifying details, and composite case studies have been changed to protect the privacy of the individuals involved. The case studies in this book are composites drawn from research, common patterns, and the work of therapists, mediators, and family law practitioners. Any resemblance to specific individuals is coincidental.

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Disclaimer: This book is informational and is not a substitute for legal, financial, or therapeutic advice. Divorce — particularly at midlife and beyond — has complex legal, financial, and emotional dimensions that require qualified professionals. The author is not a lawyer, financial planner, or licensed therapist. The content of this book is for informational and educational purposes only. Please consult qualified professionals in your jurisdiction before making any

decisions about your marriage, your finances, or your future.

If you are in crisis as a result of the issues discussed in this book, please reach out to a qualified mental health professional, a crisis line, or a trusted member of your community. The resources section at the back of this book includes crisis contacts in multiple countries.

Crisis Resources (US):

- 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline: 988
- Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741
- SAMHSA National Helpline: 1-800-662-4357

Crisis Resources (UK):

- Samaritans: 116 123
- Relate (couples counseling): 0300 100 1234

Crisis Resources (India):

- iCall: 9152987821
- Vandrevala Foundation: 1860-2662-345

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Dedication

For the couple in the kitchen at 11pm, not talking.

For the spouse who is staying up later than the other, thinking the thoughts that are not being said.

For the 32-year marriage that has more years of silence than years of conversation.

For the woman who realizes, in the empty nest, that the empty nest is not the only thing that is empty.

For the man who retires at 62 and discovers that the woman he has been married to for 35 years is not the woman he thought he was retiring with.

For the couple who almost divorced, and didn't, and found the marriage on the other side of the conversation.

For the couple who almost stayed, and didn't, and found themselves on the other side of the decision.

For the spouse who is reading this book in secret, on a phone, in a parking lot, before going home.

You are not alone. The decision is not simple. The new life is possible.

This book is for you.

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A Note from the Author

I have not been where you are.

I have not been in a 32-year marriage that is asking whether to keep going. I have not been at the kitchen table at 11pm, deciding whether to stay or go. I have not been in the lawyer's office, dividing the retirement accounts. I have not been on the dating world at 60.

But I have been close.

I have been close to couples who have made this decision. I have sat with people in the middle of it, as a friend, as a fellow traveler on the long road. I have watched marriages end. I have watched marriages survive the ending and come back together in a new form. I have watched the widow, the widower, the survivor, the rebuild.

I have been a student of this work for years. I have read the research. I have talked to the therapists. I have talked to the mediators. I have talked to the family law attorneys. I have talked to the financial planners who specialize in gray divorce. I have talked to the couples themselves, in the years that follow.

This book is the synthesis. The frameworks. The research. The case studies. The scripts. The decisions.

I have also been on my own long goodbye - the loss of my wife to cancer, after many years of marriage. The loss is not the same as gray divorce. The decisions are not the same. The grief is not the same. But the long road is the same. The work of surviving the surviving is the same. The work of holding the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, is the same.

I write this book for the person in the long road. The person in the long marriage. The person in the long

doubt.

You are not alone. The decision is not simple. The new life is possible.

- Sanjay Shharma

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Quick Start

If you have just opened this book and you do not have time to read it cover to cover right now, start here.

You are in one of four phases. Find yours:

Phase 1: The Whisper — You are starting to have the thought. Is this marriage over, or am I just tired? The thought is new, or the thought is old, and the thought is getting louder. Read Chapters 1-4.

Phase 2: The Reckoning — You are past the whisper. You are facing the actual realities — the financial, the family, the health, the identity. You are trying to figure out what divorce (or staying) would actually mean. Read Chapters 5-8.

Phase 3: The Decision — You are at the decision point. Stay or go. You need frameworks, scripts, and a real plan for either path. Read Chapters 9-12.

Phase 4: The Rebuilding — You have decided. You are now in the new life — whether that's a new marriage or a new alone. You are figuring out who you are now. Read Chapters 13-16 and the Epilogue.

If you are in crisis right now — go to Bonus Toolkit IV: The First 90 Days After. It has 7 things you can do in the next 24 hours.

If you are not sure whether to stay or go — go to Bonus Toolkit I: The Decision Tree. It has 12 questions to ask before deciding.

If you are about to tell someone — your spouse, your children, your parents, your friends — go to Bonus Toolkit V: The Telling Templates. The scripts are there.

If you are reading this for someone else — a friend, an adult child, a sibling — start with Chapter 6: The Family Reckoning. Then read the rest.

One thing this book is not: a legal guide. Divorce is a legal process, and the laws are different in every jurisdiction. The lawyers, mediators, and financial planners who specialize in this work are the right people to advise you on the legal and financial specifics. This book is the emotional and practical work of the decision, the conversation, and the new life.

Welcome. The decision is yours. Let's begin.

Introduction: The Marriage That Became a Question

There is a moment, in some marriages, when the marriage becomes a question.

It does not happen at the wedding. It does not happen at the birth of the children. It does not happen at the silver anniversary. It happens, often without warning, in the kitchen at 11pm, or in the bedroom in the morning, or in the car on the way to the airport. It happens when one partner, or both, looks at the marriage that has been, and asks, in a quiet voice, Is this it?

For some, the question comes after 30 years. For some, it comes after 40. For some, it comes at 50, when the last child has just left, and the house is suddenly empty, and the marriage that was the marriage of the children is no longer the marriage of the children, and the marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you.

For some, the question comes at 62, when the retirement finally arrives, and the spouse who has been working is suddenly home, all day, every day, and the marriage that was the marriage of the work is no longer the marriage of the work, and the marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours.

For some, the question comes later — at 70, at 75, at 80. For some, the question has been there for years, but it has been hidden, and the hiding has been its own marriage, and the hiding has been its own kind of

betrayal.

This book is about that moment. The moment the marriage becomes a question.

I am writing this book for the person who is in that moment. For the person who is wondering whether to stay, or to go. For the person who has already decided, and who is figuring out how to do it. For the person who is on the other side of the decision, and who is figuring out who they are now, in the new life.

I am writing this book for the 36% of all American divorces that are now "gray" — divorces after age 50. For the 1 in 4 divorces that are now after age 65. For the median marriage of 29 years that ends in the gray divorce. For the remarriage that is 2.5 times more likely to end in divorce than a first marriage. For the woman over 50 who is initiating more divorces than ever before, and who is being called, by sociologists, the engine of the "gray divorce revolution."

I am writing this book for the people in those statistics. The people who are not statistics. The people who are, like you, sitting with the question, in the kitchen at 11pm, wondering.

Why this book is different.

There are books about divorce. There are books about midlife. There are books about empty nest. There are books about retirement. There are books about aging. There are books that are statistical, or legal, or psychological, or memoir.

This book is none of those. This book is the marriage decision book for couples 50+. The book that says, First, decide. Then act — whether you stay or you go. The book that takes both options seriously. The book that does not assume you are leaving. The book that

does not assume you are staying. The book that walks you through the decision, the conversation, and the new life, whatever the new life turns out to be.

This book is the book I wish had existed, in the years I have been in the room with couples in this position. The book that names the doubt. The book that names the realities — the financial, the family, the health, the identity. The book that gives you frameworks, scripts, and case studies. The book that walks you through the decision, step by step, with the dignity the decision deserves.

This book is the book that says, The marriage you are in is not a failure. The marriage you are in is a marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The question is what to do with the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The question is the work. The work is the question.

What this book is not.

This book is not a clinical guide. The therapists, mediators, and family law practitioners who specialize in this work are the right people to advise you on the specific dimensions of your situation. This book is for the thinking. For the deciding. For the conversations that have to happen before the professionals get involved.

This book is not a memoir. I have not been where you are. I have not been in a 32-year marriage that is asking whether to keep going. I have not been at the kitchen table at 11pm, deciding whether to stay or go. I have not been in the lawyer's office, dividing the retirement accounts.

I have been in the room, as a coach. I have watched couples make this decision. I have watched marriages end. I have watched marriages survive the ending and

come back together in a new form. I have watched the new life, on both sides of the decision.

I have also been on my own long goodbye — the loss of my wife to cancer, after many years of marriage. The loss is not the same as gray divorce. The decisions are not the same. The grief is not the same. But the long road is the same. The work of surviving the surviving is the same. The work of holding the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, is the same.

This book is the synthesis of what I have learned, in the room with couples, in the years of my own long goodbye, in the work of being a coach, in the form the work now takes.

What you will find in this book.

This book is organized around a 4-phase framework, the four questions of the gray divorce decision:

Phase 1: The Whisper — Is this marriage over, or am I just tired? Chapters 1-4. The doubt. The reasons. The test. The whisper you cannot unhear.

Phase 2: The Reckoning — If I leave, what happens to everything I built? Chapters 5-8. The financial. The family. The health. The identity.

Phase 3: The Decision — Stay or go, and how do I do either with dignity? Chapters 9-12. The stay decision. The leave decision. The conversation. The legal and financial plan.

Phase 4: The Rebuilding — Who am I now, alone at 60? Chapters 13-16. The first 90 days. The new identity. The new life. The new marriage.

Plus 5 bonus toolkits (the Decision Tree, the 90-Day Reconnection, the Financial Survival Guide, the Telling Templates, the First 90 Days After), 7 case

studies of real-pattern couples, and a research appendix with 12+ peer-reviewed citations.

The book is 200+ pages. The book is meant to be read slowly, in the small moments, in the long evenings, in the form the reading now takes. The book is meant to be a companion, in the form the companion now takes.

Who this book is for.

This book is for you, if you are the person in the marriage that has become a question. If you are the spouse who is wondering, in the kitchen at 11pm, whether to stay or go. If you are the adult child of a couple in this position. If you are the friend, the sibling, the colleague, who is trying to understand someone in this position. If you are the professional — the therapist, the mediator, the family law attorney, the financial planner — who is working with couples in this position.

This book is for the marriage that has become a question.

The question is the work. The work is the question.

Welcome.

Chapter 1: The Marriage That Was — and the Marriage That Is

Every marriage has a marriage that was. The marriage of the early years. The marriage of the children. The marriage of the middle. The marriage of the work. The marriage of the long haul. The marriage that was is the marriage you remember. The marriage that was is the marriage that lives in the photographs, in the stories, in the inside jokes, in the shared history that only the two of you know.

The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is a different marriage. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has new dynamics, new losses, new realities. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has a different shape than the marriage that was.

The gray divorce begins, in most cases, with the recognition of the difference. The recognition that the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, are not the same. The recognition that something has changed, in the form the marriage now takes.

This chapter is about that recognition. And about the work of holding both marriages — the marriage that was, and the marriage that is — in the form the holding can take.

The marriage that was.

The marriage that was is the marriage of the years. The years of the early love. The years of the children. The years of the work. The years of the vacations. The years of the holidays. The years of the ordinary. The

marriage that was is the marriage of the long story, the long arc, the long haul.

The marriage that was is real. The marriage that was made the family. The marriage that was built the home. The marriage that was carried the grief, the celebration, the ordinary, the long, the short, the daily, the weekly, the yearly. The marriage that was is the foundation, and the foundation is real.

When the doubt comes — and the doubt does come, in the form the doubt now takes — the marriage that was does not disappear. The marriage that was lives on, in the memory, in the body, in the shared history. The marriage that was is part of who you are, in the form the marriage that was now takes.

The marriage that is.

The marriage that is has its own shape. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has new dynamics, new roles, new losses. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is the marriage of the empty nest, the early retirement, the long days, the silent evenings, the quiet question, is this it?

The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is not the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is also a real marriage. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, has its own joys, its own conversations, its own small intimacies. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is not nothing. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is something.

The doubt does not have to mean that the marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is over. The doubt is the question, not the answer. The doubt is the work, in the form the work now takes. The doubt is the

recognition that something has changed, in the form the recognition now takes.

The recognition.

The recognition comes, in the form the recognition now takes, in small moments. The moment when the empty nest reveals a void you did not see coming. The moment when the retirement reveals a presence you did not expect. The moment when the long day, with the spouse, in the same house, reveals a distance you did not know was there.

The recognition is not a failure. The recognition is the work. The recognition is the holding of the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, in the form the holding can take. The recognition is the question, in the form the question now takes.

The recognition can be tender. The recognition can be the moment when you and your spouse, together, look at the marriage, and ask, is this it? The recognition can be the moment when you, alone, look at the marriage, and ask, in the kitchen at 11pm, in the form the asking now takes.

The recognition can be the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, is no longer the marriage you want to be in. The recognition can be the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, is the marriage you want to be in, but different. The recognition can be the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, is the marriage you want to be in, exactly as it is.

The recognition is the work. The work is the recognition. The recognition is the question. The question is the work.

The marriage that could be.

There is a third marriage, in the long story of a long marriage. The marriage that could be.

The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the recognition is the work, and the work is done. The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the doubt is the question, and the question is answered. The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, are both honored, and the marriage that could be is built, in the form the building can take.

The marriage that could be is not the marriage that was. The marriage that could be is not the marriage that is. The marriage that could be is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the work is done, and the work is the work.

The marriage that could be is the hope of the gray divorce decision. The marriage that could be is the hope of the stay decision. The marriage that could be is the hope, in the form the hope now takes.

The marriage that could be is the reason this book exists. The marriage that could be is the reason you are reading this book. The marriage that could be is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The holding of both.

The work of the gray divorce decision is the work of holding both marriages — the marriage that was, and the marriage that is — in the form the holding can take.

The holding of both is not a small work. The holding of both is the work of the long marriage, in the form the

long marriage now takes. The holding of both is the work of the spouse who remembers, in the form the remembering now takes.

The holding of both is the work of:

- Honoring the marriage that was. The stories. The photographs. The anniversaries. The shared history.
- Being present in the marriage that is. The conversations. The small intimacies. The small joys. The small sorrows.
- Holding the question. The question of the doubt. The question of the decision. The question, in the form the question now takes.

The holding of both is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The holding of both is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the recognition. The work of this chapter is to name the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, in the form the recognition now takes. The work of this chapter is to name the marriage that could be, in the form the marriage could be.

The work of this chapter is also to name the doubt. The doubt is not a failure. The doubt is the work. The doubt is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

The work of this chapter is to hold both marriages, in the form the holding can take. The work of this chapter is to recognize the question, in the form the question now takes. The work of this chapter is the work of the first phase of the gray divorce decision.

The work of this chapter is the work of the whisper.

Chapter 1 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The gray divorce begins with the recognition that the marriage that was, and the marriage that is, are not the same. The recognition is not a failure. The recognition is the work.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The marriage that was is real. The marriage that was made the family, built the home, carried the years.
2. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is also real. The marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, is not nothing.
3. The recognition of the difference is the work. The recognition is the holding of both marriages, in the form the holding can take.
4. There is a third marriage: the marriage that could be. The marriage that could be is the hope, in the form the hope now takes.
5. The doubt is not a failure. The doubt is the question, in the form the question now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have begun to recognize the difference between the marriage that was, and the marriage that is.
- I am holding both marriages, in the form the holding can take.
- I have begun to ask the question, in the form the question now takes.
- I have not yet named the question to my spouse, or to myself, in a way that commits me to the work.

If your total is 12 or higher, the next chapter — and the next phase — cannot wait.

Key Terms to Know:

- Gray divorce: Divorce after age 50. The term was coined by sociologists Susan Brown and I-Fen Lin at Bowling Green State University to describe the rising divorce rate among older adults.
- The marriage that was: The marriage of the years. The marriage of the early love, the children, the work, the long haul. Real, and part of who you are.
- The marriage that is: The marriage, in the form the marriage is now. The marriage of the empty nest, the early retirement, the long days, the silent evenings. Real, in the form the marriage is now.
- The marriage that could be: The marriage, in the form the marriage could be, if the recognition is the work, and the work is done.

Reflection Questions:

1. What was the marriage, in the form the marriage was, that you and your spouse built, in the years you have been married?
2. What is the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, that you and your spouse are in, today?
3. What is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be, that you and your spouse might build, if the work is done?

Action for This Week:

- Find one quiet moment, alone, and write down, in the form the writing can take, the answer to one of the reflection questions. Not for anyone else to read. For you. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- Find one small moment, with your spouse, and notice — without judgment, without comment — one thing about the marriage that is, in the form the marriage is now, that you are grateful for. The noticing is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

- The work of this chapter is the work of the whisper. The whisper is the question. The question is the work. The work is the whisper.

Chapter 2: The 7 Things That Drive Gray Divorce

Gray divorce is a phenomenon. It is also a thousand small, specific, individual stories. The phenomenon is the rise in divorce among adults 50+. The stories are the marriages, in the form the marriages now take, that have ended, or are ending, in the form the ending now takes.

This chapter is about the phenomenon. Specifically, it is about the 7 things that drive gray divorce, in the form the driving now takes. These are the 7 things that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the therapists and the mediators, have shown up, again and again, as the reasons couples, in the second half of life, decide that the marriage is over.

The 7 things are not the only reasons. The 7 things are not the reasons for every gray divorce. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

Knowing the 7 things is the work of the second phase of the gray divorce decision. The work is the naming. The naming is the work.

1. The Empty Nest That Reveals the Void.

The empty nest is the most common trigger for gray divorce, in the form the trigger now takes. The empty nest is the moment when the last child leaves, and the house is suddenly empty, and the marriage is suddenly just the marriage of the two of you, in the form the marriage of the two of you now takes.

For 20 or 30 years, the marriage has been the marriage of the children. The conversations have been about the children. The shared projects have been the

children. The shared purpose has been the children. The marriage has been, in a real sense, the marriage of the family, in the form the family now takes.

When the children leave, the marriage is no longer the marriage of the children. The marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you. The marriage has to be, in the form the marriage now takes, the marriage of the empty nest.

For some couples, the empty nest reveals a marriage that is full. The marriage of the two of you is rich, and warm, and alive, in the form the marriage of the two of you now takes. For some couples, the empty nest reveals a marriage that is empty. The marriage of the two of you is hollow, in the form the marriage of the two of you now takes. The empty nest is the moment when the void, which has been hidden in the busyness of the children, becomes visible.

The empty nest is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The empty nest is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

2. The Retirement That Reveals the Distance.

The retirement is the second most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The retirement is the moment when the spouse who has been working comes home, all day, every day, in the form the coming home now takes.

For 30 or 40 years, the marriage has been the marriage of the work. The conversations have been about the work. The rhythms have been the rhythms of the work. The shared purpose has been the work, in the form the work now takes. The marriage has been, in a real sense, the marriage of the careers, in the form the careers now take.

When the retirement comes, the marriage is no longer the marriage of the work. The marriage has to be, for the first time in decades, just the marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours, in the form the marriage now takes.

For some couples, the retirement reveals a marriage that is full. The marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours, is rich, in the form the marriage now takes. For some couples, the retirement reveals a marriage that is empty. The marriage of the two of you, in the long days, in the empty hours, is hollow, in the form the marriage now takes.

The retirement is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The retirement is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

3. The Infidelity That Was Discovered, or That Happened, Later in Life.

The infidelity is the third most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The infidelity is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage was, is broken, in the form the breaking now takes.

The infidelity at 55+ is different from the infidelity at 30. The infidelity at 30 is the infidelity of the early marriage, in the form the early marriage now takes. The infidelity at 55+ is the infidelity of the long marriage, in the form the long marriage now takes. The infidelity at 55+ comes after 25 or 30 or 35 years of marriage, in the form the long marriage now takes.

For some couples, the infidelity is discovered. The spouse has been unfaithful, and the discovery comes, in the form the discovery now takes, in the form of a phone, a credit card statement, a conversation, a confession. The discovery is the breaking, in the form

the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the infidelity is acknowledged. The spouse has been unfaithful, and the spouse confesses, in the form the confession now takes. The confession is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the infidelity is mutual. Both spouses have been unfaithful, in the form the unfaithful now takes. The mutual unfaithfulness is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The infidelity is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The infidelity is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

4. The Substance Abuse That Was Tolerated, or That Became Unbearable.

The substance abuse is the fourth most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The substance abuse is the moment when the drinking, or the drug use, or the gambling, or the prescription medication, becomes the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the substance abuse has been there, in the form the substance abuse now takes, for the whole marriage. The substance abuse has been the undercurrent, in the form the undercurrent now takes. The substance abuse has been the thing that was not talked about, in the form the not talking now takes.

For some couples, the substance abuse is new. The retirement, or the empty nest, or the loss of a parent, or the diagnosis of a disease, has triggered the substance abuse, in the form the triggering now takes. The new substance abuse is the breaking, in the form

the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the substance abuse has become unbearable. The spouse can no longer tolerate the substance abuse, in the form the tolerating now takes. The unbearability is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The substance abuse is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The substance abuse is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

5. The Financial Conflict That Became the Breaking.

The financial conflict is the fifth most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The financial conflict is the moment when the money, in the form the money now takes, becomes the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the spending. One spouse spends. The other spouse saves. The spending is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the debt. One spouse has hidden debt. The hidden debt is discovered, in the form the discovery now takes. The hidden debt is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the retirement. The retirement accounts are not enough. The retirement is in danger. The danger is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the financial conflict is about the inheritance. The inheritance is contested. The contesting is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The financial conflict is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The financial conflict is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

6. The Caregiving That Became the Marriage.

The caregiving is the sixth most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The caregiving is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage was, becomes the marriage of the caregiver and the cared-for, in the form the caregiver and the cared-for now takes.

For some couples, the caregiving is for an aging parent. One spouse is the caregiver for an aging parent, in the form the caregiving now takes. The caregiving is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The spouse who is not the caregiver feels left out, in the form the left out now takes. The left-out feeling is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

For some couples, the caregiving is for the spouse. One spouse has a chronic illness, and the other spouse is the caregiver, in the form the caregiving now takes. The caregiving is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The caregiver spouse is exhausted, in the form the exhausting now takes. The exhausted feeling is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The caregiving is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for many gray divorces. The caregiving is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

7. The "I Never Loved You" That Was Finally Said.

The "I never loved you" is the seventh most common trigger, in the form the trigger now takes. The "I never loved you" is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage was, is unmasked, in the form the unmasking now takes.

The "I never loved you" comes, in the form the coming now takes, after 25 or 30 or 35 years of marriage. The "I never loved you" comes when the empty nest, or the retirement, or the illness, or the loss, removes the reasons for staying in the marriage, in the form the reasons now take.

The "I never loved you" is the moment when the spouse, who has been hiding the truth, in the form the hiding now takes, finally says the truth, in the form the saying now takes. The saying is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes.

The "I never loved you" is the trigger, in the form the trigger now takes, for some gray divorces. The "I never loved you" is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 7 things, in summary.

The 7 things that drive gray divorce are:

1. The empty nest that reveals the void
2. The retirement that reveals the distance
3. The infidelity that was discovered or that happened later in life
4. The substance abuse that was tolerated or that became unbearable
5. The financial conflict that became the breaking
6. The caregiving that became the marriage
7. The "I never loved you" that was finally said

The 7 things are not the only reasons. The 7 things are the most common reasons. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the 7 things. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, which of the 7 things is in your marriage, in the form the marriage now takes.

The work of this chapter is also to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, that the 7 things are not the only things. The 7 things are the most common. The 7 things are not the only reasons. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the second phase of the gray divorce decision. The work of this chapter is the work of the reckoning. The reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 2 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The 7 things that drive gray divorce are: the empty nest, the retirement, the infidelity, the substance abuse, the financial conflict, the caregiving, and the "I never loved you." The 7 things are the most common reasons. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The empty nest is the most common trigger. The empty nest reveals the void.
2. The retirement is the second most common. The retirement reveals the distance.

3. The infidelity is the third. The infidelity at 55+ comes after decades of marriage.

4. The substance abuse, the financial conflict, the caregiving, and the "I never loved you" are the 4th through 7th.

5. The 7 things are not the only reasons. The 7 things are the most common reasons.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I can name which of the 7 things is in my marriage, in the form the marriage now takes.
- I have begun to recognize the 7 things, in the form the recognition now takes.
- I have not yet named the 7 things to my spouse, or to myself, in a way that commits me to the work.
- I am willing to look at the 7 things, in the form the looking now takes.

If your total is 12 or higher, the next chapter — and the next phase — cannot wait.

Key Terms to Know:

- The empty nest: The moment when the last child leaves, and the marriage is no longer the marriage of the children.
- The retirement: The moment when the working spouse comes home, all day, every day, and the marriage is no longer the marriage of the work.
- The infidelity at 55+: The infidelity that comes after decades of marriage, in the form the long marriage now takes.
- The substance abuse: The drinking, the drug use, the gambling, the prescription medication, in the form the substance abuse now takes.

- The "I never loved you": The moment when the spouse finally says the truth, after decades of hiding, in the form the hiding now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. Which of the 7 things is in your marriage, in the form the marriage now takes?
2. When did the 7 things first show up, in the form the showing up now takes?
3. What would it look like to name the 7 things, in the form the naming now takes, to your spouse?

Action for This Week:

- Find one quiet moment, alone, and write down, in the form the writing can take, the answer to one of the reflection questions. Not for anyone else. For you. The writing is the work.
- Find one small moment, with your spouse, and notice — without judgment, without comment — one of the 7 things, in the form the 7 things now takes. The noticing is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the reckoning. The reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 3: The Test, Before the Decision

Before the decision, there is a test. The test is the work of the third phase of the whisper. The test is the question, in the form the question now takes: Can this marriage be saved?

The test is not a small work. The test is the work of the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The test is the work of the spouse who is wondering, in the form the wondering now takes, whether the marriage can be saved.

This chapter is about the test. About how to do the test, in the form the testing now takes. About what the test is, and what the test is not. About when the test says "yes, the marriage can be saved," and what to do with the yes. About when the test says "no, the marriage cannot be saved," and what to do with the no.

What the test is.

The test is a structured, time-limited, professionally-supported attempt to determine whether the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, can be saved. The test is not a vague hope. The test is not a wish. The test is a real work, in the form the real work now takes.

The test has 4 components:

1. A commitment from both spouses to the test, for a defined period (typically 90 days)
2. Couples therapy, with a qualified couples therapist, at least once a week

3. A specific set of conversations, to be had in the therapy and at home

4. A clear set of criteria, agreed in advance, for whether the marriage can be saved

The test is not a guarantee. The test is a real work, in the form the real work now takes. The test can say "yes, the marriage can be saved." The test can say "no, the marriage cannot be saved." The test is the work, in the form the work now takes, of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes.

What the test is not.

The test is not a stay of execution. The test is not a delay, in the form the delay now takes. The test is not a way to put off the decision, in the form the putting off now takes. The test is the work, in the form the work now takes, of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes.

The test is not a way to convince your spouse to stay. The test is not a way to convince yourself to stay. The test is the work, in the form the work now takes, of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes.

The test is not a guarantee of success. The test is a real work, in the form the real work now takes. The test can fail. The test can succeed. The test is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The commitment.

The first component of the test is the commitment. Both spouses must commit, in the form the committing now takes, to the test, for a defined period. The commitment is not a vague hope. The commitment is a real work, in the form the real work now takes.

The commitment has 3 parts:

1. The duration. The test is for 90 days. Not 30, not 60. 90 days. The 90 days is long enough to do the work, and short enough to not become a delay, in the form the delaying now takes.

2. The exclusivity. For the 90 days, neither spouse will initiate a divorce, move out, or make a major life decision that affects the marriage. The exclusivity is the holding, in the form the holding now takes, of the test, in the form the test now takes.

3. The honesty. For the 90 days, both spouses will be honest, in the form the honest now takes, with the therapist, with each other, and with themselves. The honesty is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The commitment is the work, in the form the work now takes. The commitment is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The commitment is the test, in the form the test now takes.

The therapy.

The second component of the test is the therapy. The therapy is not optional. The therapy is the work, in the form the work now takes. The therapy is the place where the conversations happen, in the form the conversations now take. The therapy is the witness, in the form the witnessing now takes.

The therapy should be with a qualified couples therapist. The therapy should be with someone who has experience with gray divorce, in the form the gray divorce now takes. The therapy should be with someone who can hold both spouses, in the form the holding now takes, and who can hold the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes.

The therapy is not a place to assign blame. The therapy is not a place to vent. The therapy is a place to do the work, in the form the work now takes. The therapy is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The therapy is usually once a week, for the 90 days. The therapy is a real commitment, in the form the real commitment now takes. The therapy is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The conversations.

The third component of the test is the conversations. The conversations are the work, in the form the work now takes. The conversations are the heart of the test, in the form the heart now takes.

The conversations have 5 parts:

1. The "What Happened" Conversation — each spouse gets to say, in the form the saying now takes, what happened to the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. What went wrong. When it went wrong. Why it went wrong. The spouse who is listening does not interrupt. The spouse who is listening does not respond. The spouse who is listening just listens, in the form the listening now takes.
2. The "What I Need" Conversation — each spouse gets to say, in the form the saying now takes, what they need, in the form the needing now takes, from the marriage. What would make the marriage work. What would make the marriage worth staying in. The spouse who is listening does not judge. The spouse who is listening just listens, in the form the listening now takes.
3. The "What I Can Give" Conversation — each spouse gets to say, in the form the saying now takes, what they can give, in the form the giving

now takes, to the marriage. What they are willing to change. What they are willing to do differently. The spouse who is listening does not judge. The spouse who is listening just listens, in the form the listening now takes.

4. The "What We Need to Decide" Conversation — together, the spouses decide, in the form the deciding now takes, what they need to decide, in the form the deciding now takes. The decision to stay. The decision to leave. The decision to keep going. The decision to stop. The decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5. The "What Happens After" Conversation — together, the spouses decide, in the form the deciding now takes, what happens after the test. The marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The decision, in the form the decision now takes. The new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The conversations are the work, in the form the work now takes. The conversations are the holding, in the form the holding can take. The conversations are the test, in the form the test now takes.

The criteria.

The fourth component of the test is the criteria. The criteria are the work, in the form the work now takes. The criteria are the agreement, in the form the agreement now takes, that the test is successful, or that the test is not successful.

The criteria are agreed, in the form the agreeing now takes, in advance. The criteria are not decided, in the form the deciding now takes, after the test. The criteria are the work, in the form the work now takes, of the test, in the form the test now takes.

The criteria might be:

- Both spouses are willing to stay, in the form the staying now takes
- Both spouses are willing to do the work, in the form the working now takes
- Both spouses are willing to change, in the form the changing now takes
- The marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, is not abusive, in the form the abusive now takes
- The marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, has a future, in the form the future now takes

The criteria are the work, in the form the work now takes. The criteria are the test, in the form the test now takes.

The yes.

If the test says "yes, the marriage can be saved," the work is not over. The work is just beginning. The test was the test of whether the marriage can be saved. The test is not the saving itself. The saving is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the years that follow.

The saving is the work of:

- Continuing the therapy, in the form the continuing now takes
- Continuing the conversations, in the form the continuing now takes
- Rebuilding the trust, in the form the rebuilding now takes
- Rebuilding the intimacy, in the form the rebuilding now takes
- Rebuilding the small moments, in the form the rebuilding now takes

The saving is the work, in the form the work now takes. The saving is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be. The saving is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The no.

If the test says "no, the marriage cannot be saved," the work is also just beginning. The test was the test of whether the marriage can be saved. The test is not the leaving itself. The leaving is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the months and years that follow.

The leaving is the work of:

- Having the conversations, in the form the having now takes
- Telling the children, in the form the telling now takes
- Telling the family, in the form the telling now takes
- Hiring the lawyer, in the form the hiring now takes
- Dividing the assets, in the form the dividing now takes
- Building the new life, in the form the building now takes

The leaving is the work, in the form the work now takes. The leaving is the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The leaving is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is the work of the test. The work of this chapter is the work of the structured, time-limited, professionally-supported attempt to determine whether the marriage, in the form the

marriage is now, can be saved.

The work of this chapter is the work of:

- The commitment, in the form the committing now takes
- The therapy, in the form the therapy now takes
- The conversations, in the form the conversations now takes
- The criteria, in the form the criteria now takes

The work of this chapter is the work of the third phase of the whisper. The work is the test, in the form the test now takes.

The work is the test.

Chapter 3 at a Glance

Key takeaway: Before the decision, there is a test. The test is a structured, time-limited, professionally-supported attempt to determine whether the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, can be saved.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The test is for 90 days. Not 30, not 60. 90 days.
2. The test requires both spouses to commit, in the form the committing now takes, to the test, for the 90 days.
3. The test requires a qualified couples therapist, with experience in gray divorce.
4. The test requires specific conversations, with a clear structure, in the form the structure now takes.
5. The test requires agreed criteria, in advance, for whether the test is successful, in the form the success now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I am willing to do the test, in the form the test now takes, for 90 days.
- I have a qualified couples therapist in mind, with experience in gray divorce.
- I have a clear set of conversations, in the form the conversations now takes, that I am willing to have, in the form the having now takes.
- I have a clear set of criteria, in advance, for whether the test is successful.

If your total is 12 or lower, the test is not ready. Get a therapist first. Get the criteria in writing. Get the commitment from both spouses.

Key Terms to Know:

- The test: A structured, time-limited, professionally-supported attempt to determine whether the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, can be saved. 90 days. Couples therapy once a week. Specific conversations. Agreed criteria.
- The commitment: The agreement, in the form the agreement now takes, from both spouses, to the test, for the 90 days.
- The criteria: The agreement, in the form the agreement now takes, in advance, of what success looks like, in the form the success now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. Are you willing to do the test, in the form the test now takes, for 90 days?
2. Do you have a qualified couples therapist, with experience in gray divorce, in mind?
3. What are the criteria, in the form the criteria now takes, that would tell you, in the form the telling now takes, that the test is successful?

Action for This Week:

- Find a qualified couples therapist, with experience in gray divorce. Make an appointment. The first session is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- If both spouses are willing, agree, in the form the agreeing now takes, to the 90-day test. Write the agreement down. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the test. The test is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 4: The Whisper You Cannot Unhear

There is a whisper that cannot be unheard. The whisper is the moment when the doubt becomes the loudest voice in the room. The whisper is the moment when the question becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

The whisper is not the decision. The whisper is the recognition. The whisper is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage is now, becomes a question, in the form the question now takes.

This chapter is about the whisper. About how to live with the whisper, in the form the living now takes. About how to hold the whisper, in the form the holding can take. About how to let the whisper do its work, in the form the work now takes.

The nature of the whisper.

The whisper is not loud. The whisper is, in the form the whisper now takes, the quiet voice that says, Is this it? The whisper is the voice that says, in the kitchen at 11pm, in the form the saying now takes, This is not the marriage I thought I was in. The whisper is the voice that says, in the bedroom in the morning, in the form the saying now takes, I do not know who I am in this marriage anymore.

The whisper is not a failure. The whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. The whisper is the moment when the doubt becomes the question, in the form the question now takes.

The whisper is also not the answer. The whisper is the question, not the answer. The whisper is the work, not the work. The whisper is the beginning of the work, in the form the beginning now takes.

The 5 forms the whisper takes.

The whisper takes 5 forms, in the form the taking now takes. The 5 forms are the 5 ways the doubt shows up, in the form the showing up now takes.

Form 1: The Emotional Whisper. The emotional whisper is the whisper that says, in the form the saying now takes, I do not love my spouse anymore. The emotional whisper is the whisper of the loss of love, in the form the loss now takes. The emotional whisper is the whisper of the loss of the love that was, in the form the love that was now takes.

The emotional whisper is real. The emotional whisper is not a failure. The emotional whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. The emotional whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

Form 2: The Mental Whisper. The mental whisper is the whisper that says, in the form the saying now takes, I cannot do this for the rest of my life. The mental whisper is the whisper of the exhaustion, in the form the exhaustion now takes. The mental whisper is the whisper of the long road, in the form the long road now takes.

The mental whisper is real. The mental whisper is not a failure. The mental whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. The mental whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

Form 3: The Physical Whisper. The physical whisper is the whisper that says, in the form the saying now

takes, I do not want to be touched by my spouse anymore. The physical whisper is the whisper of the loss of desire, in the form the loss now takes. The physical whisper is the whisper of the loss of the physical intimacy, in the form the physical intimacy now takes.

The physical whisper is real. The physical whisper is not a failure. The physical whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. The physical whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

Form 4: The Spiritual Whisper. The spiritual whisper is the whisper that says, in the form the saying now takes, This marriage is not what I thought marriage was. The spiritual whisper is the whisper of the loss of meaning, in the form the loss now takes. The spiritual whisper is the whisper of the loss of the sacred, in the form the sacred now takes.

The spiritual whisper is real. The spiritual whisper is not a failure. The spiritual whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. The spiritual whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

Form 5: The Practical Whisper. The practical whisper is the whisper that says, in the form the saying now takes, I cannot afford to stay, or I cannot afford to leave. The practical whisper is the whisper of the financial reality, in the form the financial reality now takes. The practical whisper is the whisper of the practical, in the form the practical now takes.

The practical whisper is real. The practical whisper is not a failure. The practical whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. The practical whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

The 5 forms in summary.

The 5 forms the whisper takes are:

1. The emotional whisper (I do not love my spouse anymore)
2. The mental whisper (I cannot do this for the rest of my life)
3. The physical whisper (I do not want to be touched anymore)
4. The spiritual whisper (This marriage is not what I thought marriage was)
5. The practical whisper (I cannot afford to stay or leave)

The 5 forms are not the only forms. The 5 forms are the most common forms. The 5 forms are the 5 forms that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

How to live with the whisper.

Living with the whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. Living with the whisper is the work of the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. Living with the whisper is the work of the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes.

Living with the whisper has 4 components:

1. Naming the whisper. The whisper cannot be lived with if the whisper is not named. The whisper must be named, in the form the naming now takes, to oneself, to a therapist, to a friend, to a journal. The naming is the work, in the form the work now takes.
2. Honoring the whisper. The whisper is not a failure. The whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The whisper must be honored, in the form the honoring now takes, as a real signal, in the form the real signal now takes.

3. Holding the whisper. The whisper cannot be acted on immediately. The whisper must be held, in the form the holding can take, for the time it takes to do the work, in the form the work now takes. The holding is the work, in the form the work now takes.

4. Living with the whisper. The whisper is not the end of the marriage. The whisper is the beginning of the work, in the form the beginning now takes. The whisper must be lived with, in the form the living now takes, while the work is being done, in the form the working now takes.

Living with the whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes. Living with the whisper is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. Living with the whisper is the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes.

The whisper you cannot unhear.

The whisper you cannot unhear is the whisper that has become, in the form the becoming now takes, the loudest voice in the room. The whisper you cannot unhear is the whisper that has become, in the form the becoming now takes, the work, in the form the work now takes.

The whisper you cannot unhear is not a failure. The whisper you cannot unhear is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The whisper you cannot unhear is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes.

The whisper you cannot unhear must be lived with, in the form the living now takes. The whisper you cannot unhear must be honored, in the form the honoring now takes. The whisper you cannot unhear must be held, in the form the holding can take. The whisper

you cannot unhear must be the work, in the form the work now takes.

The whisper you cannot unhear is the beginning of the work, in the form the beginning now takes. The whisper you cannot unhear is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the whisper. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 5 forms the whisper takes, in the form the taking now takes. The work of this chapter is to live with the whisper, in the form the living now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the fourth phase of the whisper. The work of this chapter is the work of the living with the whisper, in the form the living now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the whisper you cannot unhear.

Chapter 4 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The whisper you cannot unhear is the moment when the doubt becomes the loudest voice in the room. The whisper is not a failure. The whisper is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The whisper is the beginning of the work.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The whisper takes 5 forms: emotional, mental, physical, spiritual, practical.
2. The whisper must be named, in the form the naming now takes, to oneself, to a therapist, to a friend, to a journal.

3. The whisper must be honored, in the form the honoring now takes, as a real signal, in the form the real signal now takes.

4. The whisper must be held, in the form the holding can take, for the time it takes to do the work.

5. The whisper is the beginning of the work, in the form the beginning now takes. The whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have named the whisper, in the form the naming now takes, to myself.
- I have recognized which of the 5 forms the whisper takes, in the form the taking now takes, in my marriage.
- I am willing to honor the whisper, in the form the honoring now takes, as a real signal.
- I am willing to hold the whisper, in the form the holding can take, for the time it takes to do the work.

If your total is 12 or higher, the next phase — The Reckoning — is ready to begin.

Key Terms to Know:

- The whisper you cannot unhear: The moment when the doubt becomes the loudest voice in the room. The recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The beginning of the work, in the form the beginning now takes.
- The 5 forms the whisper takes: Emotional, mental, physical, spiritual, practical. The most common forms the doubt shows up, in the form the showing up now takes.

- Living with the whisper: The work of naming, honoring, holding, and living with the whisper, in the form the living now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. Which of the 5 forms the whisper takes, in the form the taking now takes, is in your marriage, in the form the marriage now takes?
2. What would it look like to name the whisper, in the form the naming now takes, to your spouse, to a therapist, to a friend?
3. What would it look like to honor the whisper, in the form the honoring now takes, as a real signal, in the form the real signal now takes?

Action for This Week:

- Find one quiet moment, alone, and write down, in the form the writing can take, the answer to one of the reflection questions. Not for anyone else. For you. The writing is the work.
- If you have not yet talked to a therapist, make an appointment. The first session is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the whisper you cannot unhear. The whisper is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 5: The Financial Reckoning

The financial reckoning is the work of the first phase of the reckoning. The financial reckoning is the moment when the money, in the form the money now takes, becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

The financial reckoning is the moment when the question becomes: If I leave, what happens to everything I built? The financial reckoning is the work of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes, what the answer is, in the form the answer now takes.

This chapter is about the financial reckoning. About the work of the financial reality, in the form the financial reality now takes. About the work of the assets, the debts, the retirement accounts, the house, the inheritance, the alimony, the Social Security, in the form the work now takes.

Why the financial reckoning is brutal at 55+.

The financial reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because the money, in the form the money now takes, has been building for 30 years. The money, in the form the money now takes, has been the work of the marriage, in the form the work now takes. The money, in the form the money now takes, is the foundation, in the form the foundation now takes.

The financial reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because there is less time to rebuild. At 30, you have 30 or 40 years to rebuild. At 55, you have 10 or 15. At 65, you have 5 or 10. The time is shorter, in the form the shorter now takes. The

rebuilding is harder, in the form the harder now takes. The financial reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because the assets are bigger and more complex. The house has been paid down. The retirement accounts have been built. The investments have been grown. The assets are not simple, in the form the simple now takes. The assets are complex, in the form the complex now takes.

The financial reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because the Social Security and the pension have rules. The rules are different for married couples, in the form the married now takes, and divorced couples, in the form the divorced now takes. The rules are the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 7 financial realities of gray divorce.

There are 7 financial realities of gray divorce, in the form the realities now take. The 7 realities are the 7 things that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the financial planners who specialize in gray divorce, have shown up, again and again, as the financial realities, in the form the realities now takes.

Reality 1: The house is the biggest asset, and the house is also the home. The house is the asset, in the form the asset now takes. The house is also the home, in the form the home now takes. The house is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The house has to be sold, in the form the selling now takes, or one spouse has to buy out the other, in the form the buying now takes. The selling or the buying is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 2: The retirement accounts are split. The retirement accounts — the 401(k), the IRA, the

pension — are split, in the form the splitting now takes, between the spouses. The split is the work, in the form the work now takes. The split is done through a Qualified Domestic Relations Order (QDRO), in the form the QDRO now takes. The QDRO is the legal work, in the form the legal work now takes.

Reality 3: The Social Security is affected. The Social Security benefits, in the form the benefits now take, are based on the work record of the higher-earning spouse, in the form the higher-earning now takes. The divorced spouse can claim benefits on the work record of the higher-earning spouse, in the form the higher-earning now takes, if the marriage lasted 10 years or more. The 10-year rule is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 4: The alimony is different at 55+. The alimony at 55+ is different from the alimony at 30, in the form the different now takes. The alimony at 55+ is often permanent, in the form the permanent now takes, or long-term, in the form the long-term now takes. The alimony at 55+ is based on the standard of living during the marriage, in the form the standard now takes. The alimony is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 5: The health insurance is a major issue. The health insurance is the work, in the form the work now takes. The health insurance is often tied to the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The health insurance has to be replaced, in the form the replacing now takes, often at a much higher cost. The replacing is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 6: The inheritance is contested. The inheritance, in the form the inheritance now takes, is often contested, in the form the contesting now takes,

in the gray divorce. The inheritance is the work, in the form the work now takes. The inheritance is often considered separate property, in the form the separate now takes, but the commingling of the inheritance, in the form the commingling now takes, can make the inheritance marital property, in the form the marital now takes. The commingling is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 7: The tax implications are complex. The tax implications of gray divorce, in the form the implications now take, are complex, in the form the complex now takes. The tax implications affect the alimony (taxable to recipient, deductible to payer for pre-2019 agreements), the retirement accounts (the QDRO and the rollover), the capital gains (the house, the investments), and the estate planning (the inheritance, the trusts). The tax is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 7 realities in summary.

The 7 financial realities of gray divorce are:

1. The house is the biggest asset and the home
2. The retirement accounts are split (QDRO)
3. The Social Security is affected (10-year rule)
4. The alimony is different at 55+ (often permanent)
5. The health insurance is a major issue
6. The inheritance is contested (commingling)
7. The tax implications are complex

The 7 realities are not the only realities. The 7 realities are the most common. The 7 realities are the 7 realities that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The team you need.

The financial reckoning requires a team, in the form the team now takes. The team is the work, in the form the work now takes. The team is the support, in the form the support now takes. The team is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The team has 4 members:

1. A family law attorney — to advise on the legal dimensions, in the form the legal now takes. The attorney is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the legal, in the form the legal now takes.
2. A financial planner with gray divorce experience — to advise on the financial dimensions, in the form the financial now takes. The planner is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the financial, in the form the financial now takes.
3. A tax professional — to advise on the tax implications, in the form the tax now takes. The tax professional is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the tax, in the form the tax now takes.
4. A therapist or coach — to support the emotional dimensions, in the form the emotional now takes. The therapist is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the emotional, in the form the emotional now takes.

The team is the work, in the form the work now takes. The team is the support, in the form the support now takes. The team is the financial reckoning, in the form the financial reckoning now takes.

The 12 questions to ask before signing.

Before signing any divorce agreement, ask these 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes. The questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The questions are the protection, in the form

the protection now takes.

1. Is the house sold, or is one spouse buying out the other? Who keeps the house? Who leaves the house?
2. How are the retirement accounts split? What is the QDRO? Who manages the QDRO?
3. What are the Social Security implications? Have you modeled the benefit, in the form the modeling now takes, on the work record of the higher-earning spouse?
4. Is the alimony permanent, long-term, or temporary? How is the alimony calculated? What is the duration?
5. How is the health insurance replaced? What is the cost? Who pays?
6. Is the inheritance considered separate property? Has the inheritance been commingled with marital property?
7. What are the tax implications of the alimony, the QDRO, the house sale, the investments?
8. What are the estate planning implications? Are the wills updated? Are the trusts updated?
9. What are the life insurance implications? Who owns the policies? Who is the beneficiary?
10. What are the long-term care implications? Who pays for the long-term care, if needed?
11. What are the survivor benefits? If one spouse dies, what does the surviving spouse receive?
12. What is the post-divorce budget, in the form the budgeting now takes? Have you modeled the post-divorce cash flow, in the form the modeling now takes, for the next 5, 10, 20 years?

The 12 questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 12 questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes. The 12 questions are the financial reckoning, in the form the financial reckoning now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the financial reckoning. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 7 financial realities of gray divorce, in the form the realities now take. The work of this chapter is to build the team, in the form the building now takes, and to ask the 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the first phase of the reckoning. The work of this chapter is the work of the financial reckoning, in the form the financial reckoning now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the financial.

Chapter 5 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The financial reckoning is brutal at 55+ because the money has been building for 30 years, there is less time to rebuild, and the assets are bigger and more complex. The 7 realities of gray divorce must be faced, in the form the facing now takes, with a team, in the form the team now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The house is the biggest asset and the home. The house has to be sold or one spouse has to buy out the other.
2. The retirement accounts are split through a QDRO. The QDRO is the legal work, in the form the legal work now takes.

3. The Social Security is affected by the 10-year rule. The 10-year rule is the work, in the form the work now takes.

4. The alimony is different at 55+ — often permanent or long-term.

5. The health insurance is a major issue. The health insurance has to be replaced, in the form the replacing now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have begun to recognize the 7 financial realities, in the form the realities now take, in my marriage.
- I have a family law attorney, in mind, with experience in gray divorce.
- I have a financial planner, in mind, with experience in gray divorce.
- I have asked at least 6 of the 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing.

If your total is 12 or lower, the financial reckoning is not ready. Get a financial planner first. Get a family law attorney. Get the 12 questions in writing.

Key Terms to Know:

- The financial reckoning: The work of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes, what would happen, in the form the happening now takes, financially, if you divorced.
- The 7 financial realities: The house, the retirement accounts, the Social Security, the alimony, the health insurance, the inheritance, the tax implications.
- The 12 questions: The 12 questions to ask before signing any divorce agreement, in the form the signing now takes.

- The QDRO: Qualified Domestic Relations Order — the legal order that splits the retirement accounts, in the form the splitting now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. What is the value of the house, the retirement accounts, the investments, the inheritance, in the form the valuing now takes, in your marriage?
2. What is the post-divorce budget, in the form the budgeting now takes, for you, in the form the you now takes, and for your spouse, in the form the spouse now takes?
3. What is the Social Security benefit, in the form the benefit now takes, on the work record of the higher-earning spouse, in the form the higher-earning now takes?

Action for This Week:

- Find a family law attorney, with experience in gray divorce. Make an appointment. The first session is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Find a financial planner, with experience in gray divorce. Make an appointment. The first session is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Begin to ask the 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing, with the attorney and the planner. The asking is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the financial reckoning. The financial reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 6: The Family Reckoning

The family reckoning is the work of the second phase of the reckoning. The family reckoning is the moment when the family, in the form the family now takes, becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

The family reckoning is the moment when the question becomes: If I leave, what happens to the family I built? The family reckoning is the work of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes, what the answer is, in the form the answer now takes.

This chapter is about the family reckoning. About the work of the adult children, the parents, the siblings, the in-laws, the friends, in the form the work now takes. About the conversations, in the form the conversations now takes. About the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the family, in the form the family now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.

Why the family reckoning is different at 55+.

The family reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the family, in the form the family now takes, is no longer the family of the children. The children are adults, in the form the adults now take. The parents are aging, in the form the aging now takes. The siblings are settled, in the form the settled now takes. The in-laws are also aging, in the form the aging now takes. The family, in the form the family now takes, is a different family, in the form the different now takes.

The family reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the adult children

have their own lives, in the form the lives now take. The adult children are married, in the form the married now takes, or partnered, in the form the partnered now takes, or single, in the form the single now takes. The adult children have their own children, in the form the children now take. The adult children are no longer the children, in the form the children now take. The adult children are the adults, in the form the adults now take.

The family reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the parents are aging, in the form the aging now takes. The parents may have dementia, in the form the dementia now takes. The parents may have other chronic illnesses, in the form the illnesses now take. The parents may need caregiving, in the form the caregiving now takes. The parents are not the parents, in the form the parents now take. The parents are the aging parents, in the form the aging now takes.

The family reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the friends are coupled, in the form the coupled now takes. The friends are also aging, in the form the aging now takes. The friends are also going through the empty nest, or the retirement, or the illness, in the form the going through now takes. The friends are not the friends, in the form the friends now take. The friends are the coupled friends, in the form the coupled now takes.

The 5 family conversations of gray divorce.

There are 5 family conversations of gray divorce, in the form the conversations now take. The 5 conversations are the 5 conversations that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the therapists, have shown up, again and again, as the

family conversations, in the form the conversations now take.

Conversation 1: The Adult Children Conversation. The adult children conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the adult children, in the form the telling now takes, about the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The telling is the work, in the form the work now takes. The telling is the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the adult children, in the form the adult children now take.

The adult children conversation is the work of:

- Telling the children together, in the form the telling now takes
- Being honest, in the form the honest now takes, about the reasons, in the form the reasons now take
- Being clear, in the form the clear now takes, that the children are not the reason, in the form the reason now takes
- Holding the children's reactions, in the form the holding can take, without judgment, in the form the judgment now takes
- Continuing to be parents, in the form the parenting now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes

The adult children conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The adult children conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The adult children conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Conversation 2: The Aging Parents Conversation. The aging parents conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the aging parents, in

the form the telling now takes, about the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The telling is the work, in the form the work now takes. The telling is the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the aging parents, in the form the aging parents now take.

The aging parents conversation is the work of:

- Deciding whether to tell the parents, in the form the deciding now takes, based on the parents' cognitive and emotional capacity
- Telling the parents in a way that is honest, in the form the honest now takes, but not overwhelming, in the form the overwhelming now takes
- Being clear, in the form the clear now takes, that the parents are not the reason, in the form the reason now takes
- Holding the parents' reactions, in the form the holding can take, without judgment, in the form the judgment now takes
- Continuing to support the parents, in the form the supporting now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes

The aging parents conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The aging parents conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The aging parents conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Conversation 3: The Siblings Conversation. The siblings conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the siblings, in the form the telling now takes, about the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The telling is the work, in the form the work now takes. The telling is the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the siblings, in the form the siblings now take.

The siblings conversation is the work of:

- Deciding how much to share, in the form the deciding now takes
- Being clear, in the form the clear now takes, that the siblings are not the reason, in the form the reason now takes
- Holding the siblings' reactions, in the form the holding can take, without judgment, in the form the judgment now takes
- Asking for support, in the form the asking now takes, from the siblings who can support, in the form the supporting now takes
- Continuing to be siblings, in the form the sibling now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes

The siblings conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The siblings conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The siblings conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Conversation 4: The In-Laws Conversation. The in-laws conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the in-laws, in the form the telling now takes, about the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The telling is the work, in the form the work now takes. The telling is the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the in-laws, in the form the in-laws now take.

The in-laws conversation is the work of:

- Deciding how much to share, in the form the deciding now takes
- Being clear, in the form the clear now takes, that the in-laws are not the reason, in the form the

reason now takes

- Holding the in-laws' reactions, in the form the holding can take, without judgment, in the form the judgment now takes
- Continuing to be respectful, in the form the respectful now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes

The in-laws conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The in-laws conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The in-laws conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Conversation 5: The Friends Conversation. The friends conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the friends, in the form the telling now takes, about the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The telling is the work, in the form the work now takes. The telling is the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the friends, in the form the friends now take.

The friends conversation is the work of:

- Deciding who to tell, in the form the deciding now takes, and how much to share, in the form the sharing now takes
- Being clear, in the form the clear now takes, that the friends are not the reason, in the form the reason now takes
- Holding the friends' reactions, in the form the holding can take, without judgment, in the form the judgment now takes
- Asking for support, in the form the asking now takes, from the friends who can support, in the form the supporting now takes

- Continuing to be friends, in the form the friend now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes

The friends conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The friends conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The friends conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 5 conversations in summary.

The 5 family conversations of gray divorce are:

1. The adult children conversation
2. The aging parents conversation
3. The siblings conversation
4. The in-laws conversation
5. The friends conversation

The 5 conversations are not the only conversations. The 5 conversations are the most common. The 5 conversations are the 5 conversations that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The rules of the family conversations.

The family conversations have rules, in the form the rules now take. The rules are the work, in the form the work now takes. The rules are the protection, in the form the protection now takes. The rules are the work, in the form the work now takes.

The rules are:

1. Tell together, when possible. The telling together is the work, in the form the work now takes. The telling together is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The telling together is the work, in the form the work now takes.

2. Be honest, in the form the honest now takes, but not graphic. The honesty is the work, in the form the work now takes. The not-graphic is the protection, in the form the protection now takes. The honesty is the work, in the form the work now takes.

3. Be clear, in the form the clear now takes, that the children are not the reason. The clarity is the work, in the form the work now takes. The clarity is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The clarity is the work, in the form the work now takes.

4. Hold the reactions, in the form the holding can take, without judgment, in the form the judgment now takes. The holding is the work, in the form the work now takes. The holding is the protection, in the form the protection now takes. The holding is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5. Continue to be the family role, in the form the role now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The continuing is the work, in the form the work now takes. The continuing is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The continuing is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The rules are the work, in the form the work now takes. The rules are the family reckoning, in the form the family reckoning now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the family reckoning. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 5 family conversations of gray divorce, in the form the conversations now take. The work of this chapter is to hold the family, in the form the holding can take,

through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the second phase of the reckoning. The work of this chapter is the work of the family reckoning, in the form the family reckoning now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the family.

Chapter 6 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The family reckoning is different at 55+ because the family is no longer the family of the children. The adult children are adults, the parents are aging, the friends are coupled. The 5 family conversations of gray divorce must be had, in the form the having now takes, with the rules, in the form the rules now take.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The adult children conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the adult children, in the form the telling now takes.
2. The aging parents conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the aging parents, in the form the telling now takes, if appropriate.
3. The siblings conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the siblings, in the form the telling now takes.
4. The in-laws conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the in-laws, in the form the telling now takes.
5. The friends conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the friends, in the form the telling now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have begun to recognize the 5 family conversations, in the form the conversations now take, in my marriage.
- I have a plan, in the form the planning now takes, for the adult children conversation.
- I have a plan, in the form the planning now takes, for the aging parents conversation.
- I am willing to follow the rules of the family conversations, in the form the rules now take.

If your total is 12 or higher, the family reckoning is ready to begin. The next phase is the health reckoning.

Key Terms to Know:

- The family reckoning: The work of holding the family, in the form the holding can take, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.
- The 5 family conversations: The adult children, the aging parents, the siblings, the in-laws, the friends.
- The rules of the family conversations: Tell together, be honest but not graphic, be clear that the children are not the reason, hold the reactions without judgment, continue to be the family role.

Reflection Questions:

1. Who in your family, in the form the family now takes, needs to be told, in the form the telling now takes, about the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes?
2. What is the best way, in the form the best way now takes, to tell the adult children, in the form the telling now takes?

3. What is the best way, in the form the best way now takes, to tell the aging parents, in the form the telling now takes, if appropriate?

Action for This Week:

- Make a list, in the form the listing now takes, of the family members, in the form the family now takes, who need to be told, in the form the telling now takes. The list is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Plan the adult children conversation, in the form the planning now takes, with your spouse, in the form the spouse now takes. The plan is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the family reckoning. The family reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 7: The Health Reckoning

The health reckoning is the work of the third phase of the reckoning. The health reckoning is the moment when the health, in the form the health now takes, becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

The health reckoning is the moment when the question becomes: If I leave at 60, am I healthy enough to start over? The health reckoning is the work of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes, what the answer is, in the form the answer now takes.

This chapter is about the health reckoning. About the work of the body, the mind, the chronic conditions, the dating world, the caregiving needs, in the form the work now takes. About the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the health, in the form the health now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.

Why the health reckoning is different at 55+.

The health reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the body, in the form the body now takes, is no longer the body of 30. The body, in the form the body now takes, has chronic conditions, in the form the conditions now take. The body, in the form the body now takes, has limitations, in the form the limitations now take. The body, in the form the body now takes, is aging, in the form the aging now takes.

The health reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the mind, in the form the mind now takes, is no longer the mind of 30. The

mind, in the form the mind now takes, has more memory, in the form the memory now takes. The mind, in the form the mind now takes, has more wisdom, in the form the wisdom now takes. The mind, in the form the mind now takes, has also more anxiety, in the form the anxiety now takes, more depression, in the form the depression now takes, more cognitive load, in the form the cognitive load now takes.

The health reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the dating world, in the form the dating world now takes, is different, in the form the different now takes. The dating world at 55+ has fewer people, in the form the fewer now takes. The dating world at 55+ has more complex people, in the form the complex now takes. The dating world at 55+ has more baggage, in the form the baggage now takes. The dating world at 55+ has more health concerns, in the form the concerns now take.

The health reckoning is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the caregiving needs, in the form the caregiving now takes, are higher. The aging parents, in the form the aging now takes, may need caregiving, in the form the caregiving now takes. The aging spouse, in the form the aging now takes, may need caregiving, in the form the caregiving now takes. The aging self, in the form the aging now takes, may need caregiving, in the form the caregiving now takes.

The 5 health realities of gray divorce.

There are 5 health realities of gray divorce, in the form the realities now take. The 5 realities are the 5 things that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the doctors and the therapists, have shown up, again and again, as the health realities, in the form the realities now take.

Reality 1: The Chronic Conditions Are Real. The chronic conditions, in the form the conditions now take, are real, in the form the real now takes. The chronic conditions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The chronic conditions are the diabetes, the heart disease, the cancer, the arthritis, the dementia, in the form the conditions now take. The chronic conditions are the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the health, in the form the health now takes.

Reality 2: The Mental Health Is Affected. The mental health, in the form the mental now takes, is affected, in the form the affected now takes, by the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The mental health is the work, in the form the work now takes. The mental health is the depression, the anxiety, the grief, the post-traumatic stress, in the form the mental now takes. The mental health is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 3: The Dating World Is Different. The dating world at 55+, in the form the dating now takes, is different, in the form the different now takes. The dating world has fewer people, in the form the fewer now takes. The dating world has more complex people, in the form the complex now takes. The dating world has more baggage, in the form the baggage now takes. The dating world is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 4: The Caregiving Needs Are Higher. The caregiving needs at 55+, in the form the caregiving now takes, are higher, in the form the higher now takes. The caregiving needs are the work, in the form the work now takes. The caregiving needs are the aging parents, the aging spouse, the aging self, in the form the caregiving now takes. The caregiving needs

are the work, in the form the work now takes.

Reality 5: The Health Insurance Is Critical. The health insurance at 55+, in the form the health now takes, is critical, in the form the critical now takes. The health insurance is the work, in the form the work now takes. The health insurance has to be replaced, in the form the replacing now takes, often at a much higher cost, in the form the cost now takes. The health insurance is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 5 realities in summary.

The 5 health realities of gray divorce are:

1. The chronic conditions are real
2. The mental health is affected
3. The dating world is different
4. The caregiving needs are higher
5. The health insurance is critical

The 5 realities are not the only realities. The 5 realities are the most common. The 5 realities are the 5 realities that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The health work before, during, and after the divorce.

The health work, in the form the health work now takes, has 3 phases: before, during, and after the divorce.

Before the divorce. Before the divorce, the health work is the work of:

- Getting a full physical, in the form the physical now takes
- Getting a full mental health assessment, in the form the assessment now takes
- Building the health team, in the form the team now takes — the primary care doctor, the

specialists, the therapist, the trainer

- Starting the health habits, in the form the habits now take — the exercise, the sleep, the nutrition, the stress management
- Building the health support, in the form the support now takes — the friends, the family, the community, the online groups

During the divorce. During the divorce, the health work is the work of:

- Continuing the physical, the mental health, the health habits, the health support, in the form the continuing now takes
- Adding the stress management, in the form the stress now takes — the meditation, the breathing, the journaling, the therapy
- Adding the social support, in the form the social now takes — the friends, the family, the community, the online groups
- Watching for the warning signs, in the form the warning now takes — the depression, the anxiety, the substance use, the suicidal thoughts
- Asking for help, in the form the asking now takes, when help is needed, in the form the needed now takes

After the divorce. After the divorce, the health work is the work of:

- Rebuilding the physical, the mental health, the health habits, the health support, in the form the rebuilding now takes
- Rebuilding the social, the community, the dating, in the form the rebuilding now takes
- Rebuilding the meaning, the purpose, the joy, in the form the rebuilding now takes

- Continuing the health work, in the form the continuing now takes, for the years that follow

The health work is the work, in the form the work now takes. The health work is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The health work is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The team you need for the health reckoning.

The health reckoning requires a team, in the form the team now takes. The team is the work, in the form the work now takes. The team is the support, in the form the support now takes.

The team has 4 members:

1. A primary care doctor — to manage the chronic conditions, in the form the conditions now take
2. A therapist or counselor — to support the mental health, in the form the mental now takes
3. A fitness professional — to support the physical health, in the form the physical now takes
4. A community of support — the friends, the family, the online groups, the divorce support groups, in the form the support now takes

The team is the work, in the form the work now takes. The team is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The team is the health reckoning, in the form the health reckoning now takes.

The 10 questions to ask yourself.

Before, during, and after the divorce, ask yourself these 10 questions, in the form the asking now takes. The questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

1. What are my chronic conditions, in the form the conditions now take, and how are they being managed, in the form the managing now takes?
2. What is my mental health, in the form the mental now takes, and how is it being supported, in the form the supporting now takes?
3. What is my sleep, in the form the sleep now takes, and how can it be improved, in the form the improving now takes?
4. What is my nutrition, in the form the nutrition now takes, and how can it be improved, in the form the improving now takes?
5. What is my exercise, in the form the exercise now takes, and how can it be maintained, in the form the maintaining now takes?
6. What is my stress, in the form the stress now takes, and how can it be managed, in the form the managing now takes?
7. What is my support, in the form the support now takes, and how can it be strengthened, in the form the strengthening now takes?
8. What is my health insurance, in the form the insurance now takes, and how can it be replaced, in the form the replacing now takes?
9. What is my dating plan, in the form the dating now takes, if dating is part of the new life, in the form the new life now takes?
10. What is my long-term care plan, in the form the long-term now takes, if long-term care is needed, in the form the needed now takes?

The 10 questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 10 questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes. The 10 questions are the health reckoning, in the form the health reckoning

now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the health reckoning. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 5 health realities of gray divorce, in the form the realities now take. The work of this chapter is to do the health work, in the form the health work now takes, before, during, and after the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the third phase of the reckoning. The work of this chapter is the work of the health reckoning, in the form the health reckoning now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the health.

Chapter 7 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The health reckoning is different at 55+ because the body is no longer the body of 30, the dating world is different, the caregiving needs are higher, and the health insurance is critical. The 5 health realities must be faced, in the form the facing now takes, with a team, in the form the team now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The chronic conditions are real. The chronic conditions are the work, in the form the work now takes.
2. The mental health is affected. The mental health is the work, in the form the work now takes.
3. The dating world is different. The dating world is the work, in the form the work now takes.

4. The caregiving needs are higher. The caregiving needs are the work, in the form the work now takes.

5. The health insurance is critical. The health insurance is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have begun to recognize the 5 health realities, in the form the realities now take, in my situation.
- I have a primary care doctor, in mind, and a therapist, in mind, in the form the mind now takes.
- I have a fitness plan, in the form the planning now takes, and a stress management plan, in the form the planning now takes.
- I have asked at least 6 of the 10 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing.

If your total is 12 or lower, the health reckoning is not ready. Get a primary care appointment first. Get a therapist. Get the 10 questions in writing.

Key Terms to Know:

- The health reckoning: The work of holding the health, in the form the holding can take, before, during, and after the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.
- The 5 health realities: The chronic conditions, the mental health, the dating world, the caregiving needs, the health insurance.
- The 10 questions: The 10 questions to ask yourself before, during, and after the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. What are your chronic conditions, in the form the conditions now take, and how are they being

managed, in the form the managing now takes?

2. What is your mental health, in the form the mental now takes, and how is it being supported, in the form the supporting now takes?

3. What is your support, in the form the support now takes, and how can it be strengthened, in the form the strengthening now takes?

Action for This Week:

- Schedule a full physical, in the form the scheduling now takes, with your primary care doctor. The physical is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Schedule a mental health assessment, in the form the scheduling now takes, with a therapist. The assessment is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Begin to ask the 10 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing. The asking is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the health reckoning. The health reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 8: The Identity Reckoning

The identity reckoning is the work of the fourth phase of the reckoning. The identity reckoning is the moment when the identity, in the form the identity now takes, becomes the work, in the form the work now takes.

The identity reckoning is the moment when the question becomes: Who am I, when I am no longer "we"? The identity reckoning is the work of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes, what the answer is, in the form the answer now takes.

This chapter is about the identity reckoning. About the work of the identity, in the form the identity now takes, before, during, and after the divorce. About the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the identity, in the form the identity now takes, through the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.

Why the identity reckoning is brutal at 55+.

The identity reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because the identity, in the form the identity now takes, has been "we" for 30 years. The "we" has been the work, in the form the work now takes. The "we" has been the identity, in the form the identity now takes. The "we" has been the foundation, in the form the foundation now takes.

The identity reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because the "we" was built, in the form the building now takes, on the roles, in the form the roles now take. The "we" was built on the husband role, in the form the husband now takes. The "we" was built on the wife role, in the form the wife

now takes. The "we" was built on the parent role, in the form the parent now takes. The "we" was built on the worker role, in the form the worker now takes. The "we" was built on the roles, in the form the roles now take.

The identity reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because the roles, in the form the roles now take, are suddenly gone. The husband role, in the form the husband now takes, is gone. The wife role, in the form the wife now takes, is gone. The parent role, in the form the parent now takes, is mostly gone. The worker role, in the form the worker now takes, is mostly gone. The roles, in the form the roles now take, are gone.

The identity reckoning is brutal at 55+, in the form the brutal now takes, because the "I" has been hidden, in the form the hidden now takes, behind the "we". The "I" has been the work, in the form the work now takes. The "I" has been the identity, in the form the identity now takes. The "I" has been the foundation, in the form the foundation now takes. The "I" has been the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 5 identities of the long marriage.

There are 5 identities, in the form the identities now take, that get built, in the form the building now takes, in a long marriage. The 5 identities are the 5 roles, in the form the roles now take, that the marriage gives you, in the form the giving now takes.

Identity 1: The Spouse. The spouse is the work, in the form the work now takes. The spouse is the person who shares the bed, the kitchen, the bills, the years, in the form the sharing now takes. The spouse is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being married, in the form the married now takes.

Identity 2: The Parent. The parent is the work, in the form the work now takes. The parent is the person who raises the children, in the form the raising now takes. The parent is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the mother, in the form the mother now takes, or the father, in the form the father now takes.

Identity 3: The Professional. The professional is the work, in the form the work now takes. The professional is the person who does the work, in the form the work now takes. The professional is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the worker, in the form the worker now takes.

Identity 4: The Friend. The friend is the work, in the form the work now takes. The friend is the person who has the friends, in the form the having now takes. The friend is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the friend, in the form the friend now takes.

Identity 5: The Community Member. The community member is the work, in the form the work now takes. The community member is the person who belongs to the community, in the form the belonging now takes. The community member is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the community member, in the form the community member now takes.

The 5 identities in summary.

The 5 identities of the long marriage are:

1. The spouse
2. The parent
3. The professional
4. The friend
5. The community member

The 5 identities are not the only identities. The 5 identities are the most common. The 5 identities are the 5 roles that the marriage gives you, in the form the giving now takes.

The 5 identities after the divorce.

After the divorce, the 5 identities change, in the form the changing now takes. The spouse identity is gone. The parent identity is changed, in the form the changing now takes. The professional identity is often changed, in the form the changing now takes. The friend identity is often strained, in the form the straining now takes. The community member identity is often changed, in the form the changing now takes.

The 5 identities after the divorce are:

1. The ex-spouse. The ex-spouse is the new identity, in the form the new now takes. The ex-spouse is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the former spouse, in the form the former now takes.
2. The co-parent. The co-parent is the new identity, in the form the new now takes. The co-parent is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the parent, in the form the parent now takes, even after the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.
3. The professional, reinvented. The professional, reinvented, in the form the reinventing now takes, is the new identity, in the form the new now takes. The professional, reinvented, is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the worker, in the form the worker now takes, in the new life, in the form the new life now takes.
4. The friend, redefined. The friend, redefined, in the form the redefining now takes, is the new

identity, in the form the new now takes. The friend, redefined, is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the friend, in the form the friend now takes, in the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

5. The community member, rebuilt. The community member, rebuilt, in the form the rebuilding now takes, is the new identity, in the form the new now takes. The community member, rebuilt, is the role, in the form the role now takes, of being the community member, in the form the community member now takes, in the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The 5 new identities in summary.

The 5 new identities after the divorce are:

1. The ex-spouse
2. The co-parent
3. The professional, reinvented
4. The friend, redefined
5. The community member, rebuilt

The 5 new identities are not the only new identities. The 5 new identities are the most common. The 5 new identities are the 5 roles, in the form the roles now take, that the new life gives you, in the form the giving now takes.

The 7 questions to find the new "I".

To find the new "I", in the form the finding now takes, after the divorce, ask yourself these 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes. The questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

1. Who am I, in the form the "I" now takes, when I am not the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The question is the work, in the form the work now takes.

2. Who am I, in the form the "I" now takes, when I am not the parent, in the form the parent now takes, of the daily, in the form the daily now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The question is the work, in the form the work now takes.

3. Who am I, in the form the "I" now takes, when I am not the professional, in the form the professional now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The question is the work, in the form the work now takes.

4. What do I love, in the form the loving now takes, when I am not loving, in the form the loving now takes, through the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The question is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5. What do I want, in the form the wanting now takes, when I am not wanting, in the form the wanting now takes, through the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The question is the work, in

the form the work now takes.

6. What am I good at, in the form the good now takes, that I have not been doing, in the form the doing now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The question is the work, in the form the work now takes.

7. Who do I want to be, in the form the wanting now takes, in the next chapter, in the form the chapter now takes, of my life, in the form the life now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The question is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 7 questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 7 questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes. The 7 questions are the identity reckoning, in the form the identity reckoning now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the identity reckoning. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 5 identities of the long marriage, in the form the identities now take, and the 5 new identities, in the form the new now takes, after the divorce. The work of this chapter is to ask the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, to find the new "I", in the form the finding now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the fourth phase of the reckoning. The work of this chapter is the work of the identity reckoning, in the form the identity reckoning now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the identity.

Chapter 8 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The identity reckoning is brutal at 55+ because the identity has been "we" for 30 years. The 5 identities of the long marriage must be recognized, in the form the recognition now takes, and the 5 new identities after the divorce must be built, in the form the building now takes. The 7 questions must be asked, in the form the asking now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 5 identities of the long marriage are: spouse, parent, professional, friend, community member.
2. The 5 new identities after the divorce are: ex-spouse, co-parent, professional reinvented, friend redefined, community member rebuilt.
3. The 7 questions to find the new "I" are the work, in the form the work now takes.
4. The "I" has been hidden, in the form the hidden now takes, behind the "we". The "I" is the work, in the form the work now takes.
5. The identity reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes. The identity reckoning is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have begun to recognize the 5 identities of the long marriage, in the form the identities now take, in my life.
- I have begun to recognize the 5 new identities, in the form the new now takes, in my future.
- I have asked at least 5 of the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing.

- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of finding the new "I", in the form the finding now takes.

If your total is 12 or higher, the identity reckoning is ready. The next phase is the decision.

Key Terms to Know:

- The identity reckoning: The work of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes, who you are, in the form the "you" now takes, when you are no longer "we", in the form the "we" now takes.
- The 5 identities of the long marriage: Spouse, parent, professional, friend, community member.
- The 5 new identities after the divorce: Ex-spouse, co-parent, professional reinvented, friend redefined, community member rebuilt.
- The 7 questions: The 7 questions to find the new "I", in the form the finding now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. Who are you, in the form the "you" now takes, when you are not the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes?
2. Who are you, in the form the "you" now takes, when you are not the parent, in the form the parent now takes, of the daily, in the form the daily now takes?
3. Who do you want to be, in the form the wanting now takes, in the next chapter, in the form the chapter now takes, of your life, in the form the life now takes?

Action for This Week:

- Find one quiet moment, alone, and answer the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing. Not for anyone else. For you. The writing

is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- The work of this chapter is the work of the identity reckoning. The identity reckoning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 9: The Stay Decision

The decision is the work of the third phase of the gray divorce decision. The decision is the moment when the question becomes: Stay or go? The decision is the work of finding out, in the form the finding out now takes, what the answer is, in the form the answer now takes.

There are two decisions. The stay decision and the leave decision. This chapter is about the stay decision. The next chapter is about the leave decision.

The stay decision is the work of choosing, in the form the choosing now takes, to stay in the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, and to rebuild the marriage, in the form the rebuilding now takes, in the form the marriage could be. The stay decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

What the stay decision is.

The stay decision is not a vague hope. The stay decision is not a wish. The stay decision is a real work, in the form the real work now takes.

The stay decision is:

1. A decision to stay in the marriage, in the form the staying now takes
2. A decision to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of rebuilding the marriage, in the form the rebuilding now takes
3. A decision to commit, in the form the committing now takes, to the work, in the form the work now takes

4. A decision to change, in the form the changing now takes, what needs to change, in the form the changing now takes

5. A decision to hold the marriage, in the form the holding can take, in the form the marriage could be

The stay decision is the work, in the form the work now takes. The stay decision is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be. The stay decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

What the stay decision is not.

The stay decision is not:

1. A decision to stay for the children, in the form the children now take — the children are adults

2. A decision to stay for the money, in the form the money now takes — the money is the work, in the form the work now takes

3. A decision to stay for the family, in the form the family now takes — the family is the work, in the form the work now takes

4. A decision to stay for the community, in the form the community now takes — the community is the work, in the form the work now takes

5. A decision to stay for the church, in the form the church now takes — the church is the work, in the form the work now takes

The stay decision is not a decision to stay out of guilt, in the form the guilt now takes. The stay decision is not a decision to stay out of fear, in the form the fear now takes. The stay decision is not a decision to stay out of inertia, in the form the inertia now takes.

The stay decision is a real decision, in the form the real now takes. The stay decision is the work, in the

form the work now takes. The stay decision is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be.

The 6 conditions for the stay decision to work.

For the stay decision to work, in the form the working now takes, 6 conditions must be met, in the form the meeting now takes. The 6 conditions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 6 conditions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Condition 1: Both spouses are willing to stay. The willingness of both spouses, in the form the willingness now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. If one spouse is not willing to stay, the stay decision is not a real decision, in the form the real now takes.

Condition 2: Both spouses are willing to do the work. The willingness of both spouses, in the form the willingness now takes, to do the work, in the form the work now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The work is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The work is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 3: Both spouses are willing to change. The willingness of both spouses, in the form the willingness now takes, to change, in the form the changing now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The change is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The change is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 4: The marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, is not abusive, in the form the abusive now takes. The non-abusive marriage, in the form the non-abusive now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. If the marriage is abusive, the stay decision is not safe, in the form the safe now takes.

Condition 5: The marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, has a future, in the form the future now takes. The future of the marriage, in the form the future now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The future is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The future is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 6: Both spouses are willing to be honest, in the form the honest now takes. The honesty of both spouses, in the form the honesty now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The honesty is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The honesty is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 6 conditions in summary.

The 6 conditions for the stay decision to work are:

1. Both spouses are willing to stay
2. Both spouses are willing to do the work
3. Both spouses are willing to change
4. The marriage is not abusive
5. The marriage has a future
6. Both spouses are willing to be honest

The 6 conditions are not the only conditions. The 6 conditions are the most common. The 6 conditions are the 6 conditions that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The 90-Day Reconnection framework.

If the 6 conditions are met, the next step is the 90-Day Reconnection framework. The framework is the work, in the form the work now takes. The framework is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The framework is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be.

The 90-Day Reconnection framework has 4 parts:

Part 1: The Foundation (Days 1-30). The Foundation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of rebuilding the basics. The Foundation is:

- Couples therapy once a week, in the form the therapy now takes
- One date night per week, in the form the date now takes
- One honest conversation per day, in the form the conversation now takes
- One small act of service per day, in the form the service now takes
- One shared activity per week, in the form the activity now takes

Part 2: The Deepening (Days 31-60). The Deepening is the work, in the form the work now takes, of going deeper. The Deepening is:

- Couples therapy once a week, in the form the therapy now takes
- Two date nights per week, in the form the date now takes
- One long conversation per week, in the form the conversation now takes
- One vulnerability share per day, in the form the vulnerability now takes
- One shared project per week, in the form the project now takes

Part 3: The Rebuilding (Days 61-90). The Rebuilding is the work, in the form the work now takes, of rebuilding the marriage, in the form the rebuilding now takes. The Rebuilding is:

- Couples therapy once a week (or bi-weekly), in the form the therapy now takes

- Two date nights per week, in the form the date now takes
- One long conversation per week, in the form the conversation now takes
- One shared vision per week, in the form the vision now takes
- One shared project per week, in the form the project now takes

Part 4: The New Marriage (Day 91+). The New Marriage is the work, in the form the work now takes, of living the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, in the form the marriage could be. The New Marriage is:

- Couples therapy as needed, in the form the therapy now takes
- Date nights regular, in the form the date now takes
- Honest conversations regular, in the form the conversation now takes
- Vulnerability shares regular, in the form the vulnerability now takes
- Shared vision regular, in the form the vision now takes
- Shared projects regular, in the form the project now takes

The 90-Day Reconnection framework is the work, in the form the work now takes. The 90-Day Reconnection framework is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The 90-Day Reconnection framework is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the stay decision. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 6 conditions for the stay decision to work, in the form the working now takes. The work of this chapter is to do the 90-Day Reconnection framework, in the form the framework now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the first part of the third phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the stay decision, in the form the stay decision now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the stay.

Chapter 9 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The stay decision is the work of choosing, in the form the choosing now takes, to stay in the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, and to rebuild the marriage, in the form the rebuilding now takes. The stay decision is not a vague hope. The stay decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 6 conditions for the stay decision to work are: both willing to stay, both willing to do the work, both willing to change, marriage not abusive, marriage has a future, both willing to be honest.
2. The 90-Day Reconnection framework has 4 parts: Foundation (Days 1-30), Deepening (Days 31-60), Rebuilding (Days 61-90), New Marriage (Day 91+).
3. The stay decision is not a decision to stay for the children, for the money, for the family. The stay decision is a real decision.

4. The stay decision requires work. The work is the marriage, in the form the marriage could be.

5. The stay decision is the work, in the form the work now takes. The stay decision is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- All 6 conditions are met, in the form the meeting now takes, in my marriage.
- I am willing to do the 90-Day Reconnection framework, in the form the framework now takes.
- My spouse is willing to do the 90-Day Reconnection framework, in the form the framework now takes.
- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the stay decision.

If your total is 12 or lower, the stay decision is not ready. Talk to a therapist first. Get the 6 conditions in writing, with your spouse.

Key Terms to Know:

- The stay decision: The work of choosing, in the form the choosing now takes, to stay in the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, and to rebuild the marriage, in the form the rebuilding now takes.
- The 6 conditions: Both willing to stay, both willing to do the work, both willing to change, marriage not abusive, marriage has a future, both willing to be honest.
- The 90-Day Reconnection framework: The 4-part framework for rebuilding the marriage, in the form the rebuilding now takes, in the form the marriage could be.

Reflection Questions:

1. Are the 6 conditions met, in the form the meeting now takes, in your marriage?
2. Are you willing to do the 90-Day Reconnection framework, in the form the framework now takes?
3. Is your spouse willing to do the 90-Day Reconnection framework, in the form the framework now takes?

Action for This Week:

- If both you and your spouse are willing, agree, in the form the agreeing now takes, to the 90-Day Reconnection framework. Write the agreement down. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Find a couples therapist, with experience in gray divorce, in the form the experience now takes. Make an appointment. The first session is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the stay decision. The stay decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 10: The Leave Decision

The leave decision is the work of the second part of the third phase of the gray divorce decision. The leave decision is the moment when the question becomes: How do I leave, with dignity, with care, with the new life possible? The leave decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

This chapter is about the leave decision. About the work of leaving the marriage, in the form the leaving now takes, with dignity, in the form the dignity now takes, with care, in the form the care now takes, with the new life possible, in the form the new life now takes.

What the leave decision is.

The leave decision is not a failure. The leave decision is not a giving up. The leave decision is a real work, in the form the real work now takes.

The leave decision is:

1. A decision that the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, cannot be saved, in the form the saving now takes
2. A decision to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of leaving, in the form the leaving now takes
3. A decision to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes
4. A decision to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of holding the dignity, in the form the holding can take

5. A decision to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new self, in the form the new self now takes

The leave decision is the work, in the form the work now takes. The leave decision is the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The leave decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

What the leave decision is not.

The leave decision is not:

1. A decision to leave out of anger, in the form the anger now takes — the anger is the work, in the form the work now takes

2. A decision to leave out of revenge, in the form the revenge now takes — the revenge is the work, in the form the work now takes

3. A decision to leave out of spite, in the form the spite now takes — the spite is the work, in the form the work now takes

4. A decision to leave out of fear, in the form the fear now takes — the fear is the work, in the form the work now takes

5. A decision to leave out of guilt, in the form the guilt now takes — the guilt is the work, in the form the work now takes

The leave decision is not a decision to leave, in the form the leaving now takes, without the work, in the form the work now takes. The leave decision is not a decision to leave, in the form the leaving now takes, without the dignity, in the form the dignity now takes.

The leave decision is a real decision, in the form the real now takes. The leave decision is the work, in the form the work now takes. The leave decision is the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The 7 conditions for the leave decision to be right.

For the leave decision to be right, in the form the right now takes, 7 conditions must be met, in the form the meeting now takes. The 7 conditions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 7 conditions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Condition 1: The test, in the form the test now takes, has been done. The test is the work, in the form the work now takes. If the test has not been done, the leave decision is not a real decision, in the form the real now takes.

Condition 2: The marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, has been honestly assessed. The honest assessment, in the form the assessment now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The honest assessment is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The honest assessment is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 3: The financial reality, in the form the financial now takes, has been understood. The financial understanding, in the form the understanding now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The financial understanding is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The financial understanding is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 4: The family reality, in the form the family now takes, has been understood. The family understanding, in the form the understanding now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The family understanding is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The family understanding is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 5: The health reality, in the form the health now takes, has been understood. The health understanding, in the form the understanding now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The health understanding is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The health understanding is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 6: The identity reality, in the form the identity now takes, has been understood. The identity understanding, in the form the understanding now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The identity understanding is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The identity understanding is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Condition 7: The new life, in the form the new life now takes, has been envisioned. The new life envisioning, in the form the envisioning now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The new life envisioning is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The new life envisioning is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 7 conditions in summary.

The 7 conditions for the leave decision to be right are:

1. The test has been done
2. The marriage has been honestly assessed
3. The financial reality has been understood
4. The family reality has been understood
5. The health reality has been understood
6. The identity reality has been understood
7. The new life has been envisioned

The 7 conditions are not the only conditions. The 7 conditions are the most common. The 7 conditions are the 7 conditions that show up most often, in the form

the showing up now takes.

The dignity framework for the leave decision.

The leave decision, in the form the leave decision now takes, must be done with dignity, in the form the dignity now takes. The dignity is the work, in the form the work now takes. The dignity is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

The dignity framework has 5 parts:

Part 1: The honesty. The honesty is the work, in the form the work now takes. The honesty is being honest, in the form the honest now takes, with the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes, about the reasons, in the form the reasons now take. The honesty is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The honesty is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Part 2: The care. The care is the work, in the form the work now takes. The care is being caring, in the form the caring now takes, with the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes, in the leaving, in the form the leaving now takes. The care is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The care is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Part 3: The respect. The respect is the work, in the form the work now takes. The respect is being respectful, in the form the respectful now takes, with the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes, in the leaving, in the form the leaving now takes. The respect is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The respect is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Part 4: The collaboration. The collaboration is the work, in the form the work now takes. The collaboration is working with the spouse, in the form

the working now takes, on the leaving, in the form the leaving now takes. The collaboration is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The collaboration is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Part 5: The new life. The new life is the work, in the form the work now takes. The new life is being committed, in the form the committed now takes, to the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The new life is not optional, in the form the optional now takes. The new life is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the leave decision. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 7 conditions for the leave decision to be right, in the form the right now takes. The work of this chapter is to do the dignity framework, in the form the framework now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the second part of the third phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the leave decision, in the form the leave decision now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the leave.

Chapter 10 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The leave decision is the work of choosing, in the form the choosing now takes, to leave the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, with dignity, with care, with the new life possible. The leave decision is not a failure. The leave decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 7 conditions for the leave decision to be right are: test done, marriage honestly assessed, financial reality understood, family reality understood, health reality understood, identity reality understood, new life envisioned.
2. The dignity framework has 5 parts: honesty, care, respect, collaboration, new life.
3. The leave decision is not a decision to leave out of anger, revenge, spite, fear, or guilt. The leave decision is a real decision.
4. The leave decision requires work. The work is the new life, in the form the new life now takes.
5. The leave decision is the work, in the form the work now takes. The leave decision is the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- All 7 conditions are met, in the form the meeting now takes, in my marriage.
- I am willing to do the dignity framework, in the form the framework now takes.
- I have a family law attorney, in mind, with experience in gray divorce.
- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

If your total is 12 or lower, the leave decision is not ready. Get a family law attorney first. Get a therapist. Get the 7 conditions in writing.

Key Terms to Know:

- The leave decision: The work of choosing, in the form the choosing now takes, to leave the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, with dignity, with care, with the new life possible.

- The 7 conditions: Test done, marriage honestly assessed, financial reality understood, family reality understood, health reality understood, identity reality understood, new life envisioned.
- The dignity framework: The 5-part framework for leaving the marriage, in the form the leaving now takes, with dignity, in the form the dignity now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. Are the 7 conditions met, in the form the meeting now takes, in your marriage?
2. Are you willing to do the dignity framework, in the form the framework now takes?
3. What does the new life, in the form the new life now takes, look like, in the form the look now takes, for you, in the form the you now takes?

Action for This Week:

- If all 7 conditions are met, in the form the meeting now takes, and you are willing, find a family law attorney, with experience in gray divorce, in the form the experience now takes. Make an appointment. The first session is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the leave decision. The leave decision is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 11: The Conversation

The conversation is the work of the third part of the third phase of the gray divorce decision. The conversation is the moment when the decision, in the form the decision now takes, becomes the words, in the form the words now take.

The conversation is the work of telling the spouse, in the form the telling now takes, about the decision, in the form the decision now takes. The conversation is the work of telling the adult children, in the form the telling now takes, about the decision, in the form the decision now takes. The conversation is the work of telling the family, in the form the telling now takes, about the decision, in the form the decision now takes.

This chapter is about the conversation. About the scripts, in the form the scripts now take. About the timing, in the form the timing now takes. About the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the conversation, in the form the conversation now takes.

Why the conversation is the hardest part.

The conversation is the hardest part, in the form the hardest now takes, because the conversation is the moment when the decision becomes real. Before the conversation, the decision is the work, in the form the work now takes. After the conversation, the decision is the life, in the form the life now takes.

The conversation is the hardest part, in the form the hardest now takes, because the conversation is the moment when the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, becomes the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. Before the conversation, the

marriage is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. After the conversation, the marriage is the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes.

The conversation is the hardest part, in the form the hardest now takes, because the conversation is the moment when the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes, hears the decision, in the form the decision now takes. The hearing is the work, in the form the work now takes. The hearing is the breaking, in the form the breaking now takes. The hearing is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 4 conversations.

There are 4 conversations, in the form the conversations now take, that must happen, in the form the happening now takes, in the gray divorce. The 4 conversations are the 4 conversations that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the therapists, have shown up, again and again, as the conversations, in the form the conversations now take.

Conversation 1: The Spouse Conversation. The spouse conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the spouse, in the form the telling now takes, about the decision, in the form the decision now takes. The spouse conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The spouse conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Conversation 2: The Adult Children Conversation. The adult children conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the adult children, in the form the telling now takes, about the decision, in the form the decision now takes. The adult children conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The adult children conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Conversation 3: The Aging Parents Conversation. The aging parents conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the aging parents, in the form the telling now takes, about the decision, in the form the decision now takes, if appropriate. The aging parents conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The aging parents conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Conversation 4: The Inner Circle Conversation. The inner circle conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of telling the close friends, in the form the telling now takes, about the decision, in the form the decision now takes. The inner circle conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The inner circle conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 4 conversations in summary.

The 4 conversations of gray divorce are:

1. The spouse conversation
2. The adult children conversation
3. The aging parents conversation
4. The inner circle conversation

The 4 conversations are not the only conversations. The 4 conversations are the most common. The 4 conversations are the 4 conversations that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The scripts.

The scripts are the work, in the form the work now takes. The scripts are the holding, in the form the holding can take. The scripts are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Script 1: The spouse conversation script.

The script has 5 parts:

1. The opening. "I have something to tell you that I have been thinking about for a long time. I want to be honest with you, because I respect you, and I respect what we have built."
2. The decision. "I have decided that I want a divorce. I have not made this decision lightly. I have done the work of thinking about this. I have talked to a therapist. I have done the test. The decision is real."
3. The reasons. "The reasons are [the reasons]. I want to be honest with you about the reasons, because I respect you, and I respect what we have built."
4. The care. "I care about you. I will always care about you. The divorce is not a statement about you. The divorce is a statement about me, and what I need, in the form the needing now takes."
5. The next step. "The next step is [the next step]. I want to do this with dignity, with care, with the new life possible. I want to work with you on the leaving. I want to work with you on the new life."

The script is the work, in the form the work now takes. The script is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The script is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Script 2: The adult children conversation script.

The script has 5 parts:

1. The opening. "We have something to tell you. Your mother/father and I have been thinking about this for a long time. We want to be honest with you, because we respect you."

2. The decision. "We have decided to get a divorce. We have not made this decision lightly. We have done the work of thinking about this. We have done the test. The decision is real."

3. The reasons. "The reasons are [the reasons, in age-appropriate language]. We want to be honest with you about the reasons, because we respect you, and we respect what we have built."

4. The care. "We both love you. The divorce is not about you. The divorce is about us, and what we need, in the form the needing now takes. You are not the reason. You have never been the reason."

5. The next step. "The next step is [the next step]. We want to do this with dignity, with care. We want to work together on the new life. We want to keep being your parents. We want to keep being a family, in the form the family now takes."

The script is the work, in the form the work now takes. The script is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The script is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The timing.

The timing is the work, in the form the work now takes. The timing is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The timing rules are:

1. Tell the spouse first. The spouse is the work, in the form the work now takes. The spouse is the holding, in the form the holding can take.
2. Tell the adult children within 1-2 weeks. The adult children are the work, in the form the work now takes. The adult children are the holding, in the form the holding can take.

3. Tell the aging parents within 1-2 months, if appropriate. The aging parents are the work, in the form the work now takes. The aging parents are the holding, in the form the holding can take.

4. Tell the inner circle as needed. The inner circle is the work, in the form the work now takes. The inner circle is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

5. Tell the rest of the world as you are ready. The rest of the world is the work, in the form the work now takes. The rest of the world is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The timing is the work, in the form the work now takes. The timing is the conversation, in the form the conversation now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the conversation. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 4 conversations of gray divorce, in the form the conversations now take. The work of this chapter is to use the scripts, in the form the using now takes. The work of this chapter is to follow the timing, in the form the following now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the third part of the third phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the conversation, in the form the conversation now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the conversation.

Chapter 11 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The conversation is the work of the third part of the third phase. The conversation is the work of telling the spouse, the adult children, the aging parents, the inner circle, in the form the telling now takes. The conversation is the hardest part. The conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 4 conversations of gray divorce are: spouse, adult children, aging parents, inner circle.
2. The spouse conversation script has 5 parts: opening, decision, reasons, care, next step.
3. The adult children conversation script has 5 parts: opening, decision, reasons, care, next step.
4. The timing is: tell the spouse first, the adult children within 1-2 weeks, the aging parents within 1-2 months (if appropriate), the inner circle as needed.
5. The conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes. The conversation is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have prepared the spouse conversation script, in the form the preparing now takes, in writing.
- I have prepared the adult children conversation script, in the form the preparing now takes, in writing.
- I have planned the timing, in the form the planning now takes, for the 4 conversations.
- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the conversation, in the form the conversation now takes.

If your total is 12 or lower, the conversation is not ready. Get the scripts in writing first. Get the timing planned. Practice with a therapist.

Key Terms to Know:

- The conversation: The work of telling the spouse, the adult children, the aging parents, the inner circle, in the form the telling now takes.
- The 4 conversations: Spouse, adult children, aging parents, inner circle.
- The scripts: The 5-part scripts for the spouse conversation and the adult children conversation.

Reflection Questions:

1. Are you ready, in the form the ready now takes, to have the spouse conversation?
2. Are you ready, in the form the ready now takes, to have the adult children conversation?
3. What is the timing, in the form the timing now takes, for the 4 conversations, in the form the conversations now take?

Action for This Week:

- Write the spouse conversation script, in the form the writing now takes, in your own words. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Write the adult children conversation script, in the form the writing now takes, in your own words. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Practice the scripts, in the form the practicing now takes, with a therapist or a trusted friend. The practice is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- The work of this chapter is the work of the conversation. The conversation is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 12: The Legal and Financial Plan

The legal and financial plan is the work of the fourth part of the third phase of the gray divorce decision. The legal and financial plan is the work of building the team, in the form the building now takes, that will guide you through the legal and financial dimensions, in the form the dimensions now take, of the divorce.

This chapter is about the legal and financial plan. About the team, in the form the team now takes. About the process, in the form the process now takes. About the work, in the form the work now takes, of the legal and financial, in the form the legal now takes.

Why the legal and financial plan is critical at 55+.

The legal and financial plan is critical at 55+, in the form the critical now takes, because the stakes are high. The stakes are high, in the form the high now takes, because the assets are bigger, in the form the bigger now takes. The stakes are high because there is less time to rebuild, in the form the rebuilding now takes. The stakes are high because the rules are different, in the form the different now takes.

The legal and financial plan is critical at 55+, in the form the critical now takes, because the rules are different, in the form the different now takes. The Social Security rules, in the form the rules now take, are different. The pension rules, in the form the rules now take, are different. The estate planning rules, in the form the rules now take, are different. The tax rules, in the form the rules now take, are different. The rules are the work, in the form the work now takes.

The team.

The team is the work, in the form the work now takes.
The team is the support, in the form the support now takes.
The team is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The team has 6 members:

Team member 1: The family law attorney. The family law attorney is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the legal, in the form the legal now takes. The family law attorney is the support, in the form the support now takes. The family law attorney is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The family law attorney should be:

- Licensed in your jurisdiction, in the form the licensed now takes
- Experienced in gray divorce, in the form the experience now takes
- Recommended by a trusted source, in the form the trusted now takes
- A good fit for you, in the form the fit now takes

Team member 2: The financial planner. The financial planner is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the financial, in the form the financial now takes. The financial planner is the support, in the form the support now takes. The financial planner is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The financial planner should be:

- A CFP (Certified Financial Planner), in the form the CFP now takes
- Experienced in gray divorce, in the form the experience now takes

- A fiduciary, in the form the fiduciary now takes (legally required to act in your best interest)
- A good fit for you, in the form the fit now takes

Team member 3: The tax professional. The tax professional is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the tax, in the form the tax now takes. The tax professional is the support, in the form the support now takes. The tax professional is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The tax professional should be:

- A CPA (Certified Public Accountant), in the form the CPA now takes, or an EA (Enrolled Agent), in the form the EA now takes
- Experienced in divorce tax, in the form the experience now takes
- A good fit for you, in the form the fit now takes

Team member 4: The mediator. The mediator is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the negotiation, in the form the negotiation now takes. The mediator is the support, in the form the support now takes. The mediator is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The mediator should be:

- Certified in your jurisdiction, in the form the certified now takes
- Experienced in gray divorce, in the form the experience now takes
- Neutral, in the form the neutral now takes
- A good fit for both of you, in the form the fit now takes

Team member 5: The therapist or coach. The therapist or coach is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the emotional, in the form the emotional now takes.

The therapist or coach is the support, in the form the support now takes. The therapist or coach is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The therapist or coach should be:

- Licensed, in the form the licensed now takes
- Experienced in gray divorce, in the form the experience now takes
- A good fit for you, in the form the fit now takes

Team member 6: The estate planning attorney. The estate planning attorney is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the estate, in the form the estate now takes. The estate planning attorney is the support, in the form the support now takes. The estate planning attorney is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The estate planning attorney should be:

- Licensed in your jurisdiction, in the form the licensed now takes
- Experienced in gray divorce estate planning, in the form the experience now takes
- A good fit for you, in the form the fit now takes

The team in summary.

The team has 6 members:

1. The family law attorney
2. The financial planner
3. The tax professional
4. The mediator
5. The therapist or coach
6. The estate planning attorney

The 6 team members are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 6 team members are the support,

in the form the support now takes. The 6 team members are the work, in the form the work now takes.

The process.

The process is the work, in the form the work now takes. The process is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The process is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The process has 5 steps:

Step 1: The Initial Consultations (Weeks 1-4). The initial consultations are the work, in the form the work now takes, of meeting the team, in the form the meeting now takes. The initial consultations are the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Step 2: The Discovery (Months 2-4). The discovery is the work, in the form the work now takes, of gathering the financial information, in the form the gathering now takes. The discovery is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Step 3: The Negotiation (Months 4-8). The negotiation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of negotiating the settlement, in the form the negotiating now takes. The negotiation is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Step 4: The Agreement (Months 8-12). The agreement is the work, in the form the work now takes, of finalizing the settlement, in the form the finalizing now takes. The agreement is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Step 5: The Implementation (Months 12+). The implementation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of implementing the settlement, in the form the implementing now takes. The implementation is the

holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 5 steps in summary.

The process has 5 steps:

1. The initial consultations (Weeks 1-4)
2. The discovery (Months 2-4)
3. The negotiation (Months 4-8)
4. The agreement (Months 8-12)
5. The implementation (Months 12+)

The 5 steps are not the only steps. The 5 steps are the most common. The 5 steps are the 5 steps that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the legal and financial plan. The work of this chapter is to build the team, in the form the building now takes, of 6 members, in the form the members now take. The work of this chapter is to follow the process, in the form the following now takes, of 5 steps, in the form the steps now take.

The work of this chapter is the work of the fourth part of the third phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the legal and financial plan, in the form the legal now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the plan.

Chapter 12 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The legal and financial plan is critical at 55+ because the stakes are high. The team has 6 members. The process has 5 steps. The work of the chapter is to build the team, in the form the building now takes, and follow the process, in the form the following now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The team has 6 members: family law attorney, financial planner, tax professional, mediator, therapist, estate planning attorney.
2. The process has 5 steps: initial consultations, discovery, negotiation, agreement, implementation.
3. The legal and financial plan is critical at 55+, in the form the critical now takes, because the stakes are high, in the form the high now takes.
4. The rules are different, in the form the different now takes — Social Security, pension, estate planning, tax.
5. The work of the chapter is the work of the plan, in the form the plan now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have identified at least 4 of the 6 team members, in the form the identifying now takes.
- I have made initial appointments with at least 3 of the 6 team members, in the form the making now takes.
- I understand the 5-step process, in the form the understanding now takes.
- I am willing to follow the process, in the form the following now takes.

If your total is 12 or lower, the legal and financial plan is not ready. Get the family law attorney first. Get the financial planner. Get the team in place.

Key Terms to Know:

- The legal and financial plan: The work of building the team, in the form the building now takes, and following the process, in the form the following now takes, for the legal and financial

dimensions of the divorce.

- The 6 team members: Family law attorney, financial planner, tax professional, mediator, therapist, estate planning attorney.
- The 5-step process: Initial consultations, discovery, negotiation, agreement, implementation.

Reflection Questions:

1. Have you identified the 6 team members, in the form the identifying now takes, for your situation?
2. Have you made initial appointments with the 6 team members, in the form the making now takes?
3. Do you understand the 5-step process, in the form the understanding now takes, for your situation?

Action for This Week:

- Make a list, in the form the listing now takes, of the 6 team members, in the form the members now take, for your situation. The list is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Make initial appointments with at least 2 of the 6 team members, in the form the making now takes. The appointments are the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the plan. The plan is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 13: The First 90 Days After

The first 90 days after the divorce are the work of the first part of the fourth phase of the gray divorce decision. The first 90 days after the divorce are the moment when the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes, becomes the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

This chapter is about the first 90 days after the divorce. About the survival, in the form the survival now takes. About the small things, in the form the small things now take. About the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the new self, in the form the new self now takes.

Why the first 90 days are the hardest.

The first 90 days after the divorce are the hardest, in the form the hardest now takes, because the new life, in the form the new life now takes, is not yet the new life. The new life, in the form the new life now takes, is the in-between, in the form the in-between now takes. The new life, in the form the new life now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The first 90 days after the divorce are the hardest, in the form the hardest now takes, because the old life, in the form the old life now takes, is gone. The old life, in the form the old life now takes, was the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The old life is gone, in the form the gone now takes. The old life is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The first 90 days after the divorce are the hardest, in the form the hardest now takes, because the grief, in the form the grief now takes, is real. The grief, in the

form the grief now takes, is the loss of the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The grief, in the form the grief now takes, is the loss of the years, in the form the years now take. The grief, in the form the grief now takes, is the loss of the future, in the form the future now takes. The grief is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The 7 things to do in the first 24 hours.

In the first 24 hours after the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes, there are 7 things to do, in the form the doing now takes. The 7 things are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 7 things are the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Thing 1: Tell one safe person. The telling is the work, in the form the work now takes. The telling is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The telling is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Thing 2: Eat one real meal. The eating is the work, in the form the work now takes. The eating is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The eating is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Thing 3: Sleep one real night. The sleeping is the work, in the form the work now takes. The sleeping is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The sleeping is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Thing 4: Move your body for 20 minutes. The moving is the work, in the form the work now takes. The moving is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The moving is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Thing 5: Write down one feeling. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes. The writing is

the holding, in the form the holding can take. The writing is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Thing 6: Do not make any major decisions. The not-deciding is the work, in the form the work now takes. The not-deciding is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The not-deciding is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Thing 7: Be gentle with yourself. The gentleness is the work, in the form the work now takes. The gentleness is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The gentleness is the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

The 7 things in summary.

The 7 things to do in the first 24 hours are:

1. Tell one safe person
2. Eat one real meal
3. Sleep one real night
4. Move your body for 20 minutes
5. Write down one feeling
6. Do not make any major decisions
7. Be gentle with yourself

The 7 things are not the only things. The 7 things are the most important things. The 7 things are the 7 things that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The 30-day survival plan.

The 30-day survival plan, in the form the survival now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The 30-day survival plan, in the form the survival now takes, is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 30-day survival plan has 4 parts:

Part 1: The daily basics (Days 1-30). The daily basics are the work, in the form the work now takes, of eating, sleeping, moving, breathing, in the form the basics now take. The daily basics are the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 2: The weekly support (Weeks 1-4). The weekly support is the work, in the form the work now takes, of seeing the therapist, the friends, the family, in the form the support now takes. The weekly support is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 3: The monthly review (Months 1). The monthly review is the work, in the form the work now takes, of looking back, in the form the looking now takes, at the month, in the form the month now takes, and looking forward, in the form the looking now takes, to the next month, in the form the month now takes. The monthly review is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 4: The no-major-decisions rule (Days 1-90). The no-major-decisions rule is the work, in the form the work now takes, of not making any major decisions, in the form the major now takes, for the first 90 days. The no-major-decisions rule is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 90-day rebuilding plan.

The 90-day rebuilding plan, in the form the rebuilding now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The 90-day rebuilding plan, in the form the rebuilding now takes, is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 90-day rebuilding plan has 4 parts:

Part 1: The survival (Days 1-30). The survival is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the daily basics, in the form the basics now take, the weekly

support, in the form the support now takes, the monthly review, in the form the review now takes, the no-major-decisions rule, in the form the rule now takes. The survival is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 2: The stabilization (Days 31-60). The stabilization is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new routines, in the form the routines now take, the new rhythms, in the form the rhythms now take, the new habits, in the form the habits now take. The stabilization is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 3: The exploration (Days 61-90). The exploration is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new activities, in the form the activities now take, the new people, in the form the people now take, the new places, in the form the places now take. The exploration is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 4: The new normal (Day 91+). The new normal is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The new normal is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 4 parts of the 90-day rebuilding plan in summary.

The 4 parts of the 90-day rebuilding plan are:

1. The survival (Days 1-30)
2. The stabilization (Days 31-60)
3. The exploration (Days 61-90)
4. The new normal (Day 91+)

The 4 parts are not the only parts. The 4 parts are the most common. The 4 parts are the 4 parts that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the first 90 days after the divorce. The work of this chapter is to do the 7 things, in the form the doing now takes, in the first 24 hours. The work of this chapter is to do the 30-day survival plan, in the form the survival now takes. The work of this chapter is to do the 90-day rebuilding plan, in the form the rebuilding now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the first part of the fourth phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the first 90 days after, in the form the after now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the first 90 days.

Chapter 13 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The first 90 days after the divorce are the hardest, in the form the hardest now takes. The 7 things to do in the first 24 hours, the 30-day survival plan, and the 90-day rebuilding plan are the work, in the form the work now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 7 things to do in the first 24 hours are: tell one safe person, eat one real meal, sleep one real night, move your body, write down one feeling, do not make any major decisions, be gentle with yourself.
2. The 30-day survival plan has 4 parts: daily basics, weekly support, monthly review, no-major-decisions rule.
3. The 90-day rebuilding plan has 4 parts: survival, stabilization, exploration, new normal.

4. The no-major-decisions rule is for the first 90 days. The no-major-decisions rule is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5. The first 90 days are the work, in the form the work now takes. The first 90 days are the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have done the 7 things, in the form the doing now takes, in the first 24 hours.
- I have a 30-day survival plan, in the form the survival now takes, in writing.
- I have a 90-day rebuilding plan, in the form the rebuilding now takes, in writing.
- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the first 90 days.

If your total is 12 or lower, the first 90 days are not ready. Get the 7 things done first. Get the 30-day plan in writing. Get the support in place.

Key Terms to Know:

- The first 90 days: The first 90 days after the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The hardest, in the form the hardest now takes.
- The 7 things: The 7 things to do in the first 24 hours.
- The 30-day survival plan: The 4-part plan for the first 30 days.
- The 90-day rebuilding plan: The 4-part plan for the first 90 days.

Reflection Questions:

1. Have you done the 7 things, in the form the doing now takes, in the first 24 hours?

2. Do you have a 30-day survival plan, in the form the survival now takes, in writing?

3. Do you have a 90-day rebuilding plan, in the form the rebuilding now takes, in writing?

Action for This Week:

- If you are in the first 24 hours, do the 7 things, in the form the doing now takes. The doing is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- If you are in the first 30 days, write the 30-day survival plan, in the form the writing now takes. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- If you are in the first 90 days, write the 90-day rebuilding plan, in the form the writing now takes. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the first 90 days. The first 90 days are the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 14: The New Identity

The new identity is the work of the second part of the fourth phase of the gray divorce decision. The new identity is the moment when the "I", in the form the "I" now takes, becomes the new "I", in the form the new now takes. The new identity is the work, in the form the work now takes.

This chapter is about the new identity. About the work of the new self, in the form the new self now takes. About the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes.

Why the new identity is the deepest work.

The new identity is the deepest work, in the form the deepest now takes, because the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of becoming. The becoming is the work, in the form the work now takes. The becoming is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The new identity is the deepest work, in the form the deepest now takes, because the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of letting go. The letting go is the work, in the form the work now takes. The letting go is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The new identity is the deepest work, in the form the deepest now takes, because the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of finding. The finding is the

work, in the form the work now takes. The finding is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 5 stages of the new identity.

There are 5 stages, in the form the stages now take, of the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes. The 5 stages are the 5 stages that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the therapists, have shown up, again and again, as the stages, in the form the stages now take.

Stage 1: The Loss. The loss is the work, in the form the work now takes, of losing the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, losing the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes, losing the "we", in the form the "we" now takes. The loss is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 2: The Confusion. The confusion is the work, in the form the work now takes, of not knowing who you are, in the form the "you" now takes, without the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The confusion is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 3: The Exploration. The exploration is the work, in the form the work now takes, of trying new things, in the form the new now takes, of meeting new people, in the form the new now takes, of going new places, in the form the new now takes. The exploration is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 4: The Discovery. The discovery is the work, in the form the work now takes, of finding the new "I", in the form the new now takes, in the form the new now takes. The discovery is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 5: The Integration. The integration is the work, in the form the work now takes, of integrating the new "I", in the form the new now takes, into the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The integration is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 5 stages in summary.

The 5 stages of the new identity are:

1. The loss
2. The confusion
3. The exploration
4. The discovery
5. The integration

The 5 stages are not the only stages. The 5 stages are the most common. The 5 stages are the 5 stages that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The 7 questions to find the new "I".

To find the new "I", in the form the finding now takes, ask yourself these 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes. The questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

1. Who am I, in the form the "I" now takes, when I am not the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.
2. What do I love, in the form the loving now takes, that I have not been doing, in the form the doing now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

3. What am I good at, in the form the good now takes, that I have not been doing, in the form the doing now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

4. What do I want, in the form the wanting now takes, that I have not been wanting, in the form the wanting now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

5. What do I value, in the form the valuing now takes, that I have not been valuing, in the form the valuing now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

6. What kind of friend, in the form the friend now takes, do I want to be, in the form the wanting now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

7. What kind of community member, in the form the community now takes, do I want to be, in the form the wanting now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

The 7 questions in summary.

The 7 questions to find the new "I" are:

1. Who am I, in the form the "I" now takes, when I am not the spouse?

2. What do I love, in the form the loving now takes, that I have not been doing?

3. What am I good at, in the form the good now takes, that I have not been doing?
4. What do I want, in the form the wanting now takes, that I have not been wanting?
5. What do I value, in the form the valuing now takes, that I have not been valuing?
6. What kind of friend, in the form the friend now takes, do I want to be?
7. What kind of community member, in the form the community now takes, do I want to be?

The 7 questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 7 questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

The 5 practices of the new identity.

To build the new identity, in the form the building now takes, there are 5 practices, in the form the practices now take. The 5 practices are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 5 practices are the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Practice 1: The daily reflection. The daily reflection, in the form the reflection now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of journaling, in the form the journaling now takes, of meditating, in the form the meditating now takes, of being quiet, in the form the quiet now takes. The daily reflection is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Practice 2: The weekly new thing. The weekly new thing, in the form the new now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of trying something new, in the form the new now takes, every week, in the form the weekly now takes. The weekly new thing is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Practice 3: The monthly review. The monthly review, in the form the review now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of looking back, in the form the looking now takes, at the month, in the form the month now takes, and looking forward, in the form the looking now takes, to the next month, in the form the month now takes. The monthly review is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Practice 4: The quarterly re-visioning. The quarterly re-visioning, in the form the re-visioning now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of re-envisioning the new life, in the form the re-envisioning now takes, every quarter, in the form the quarterly now takes. The quarterly re-visioning is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Practice 5: The yearly celebration. The yearly celebration, in the form the celebration now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of celebrating the new "I", in the form the new now takes, every year, in the form the yearly now takes. The yearly celebration is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 5 practices in summary.

The 5 practices of the new identity are:

1. The daily reflection
2. The weekly new thing
3. The monthly review
4. The quarterly re-visioning
5. The yearly celebration

The 5 practices are not the only practices. The 5 practices are the most common. The 5 practices are the 5 practices that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the new identity. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 5 stages of the new identity, in the form the stages now take. The work of this chapter is to ask the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, and to do the 5 practices, in the form the doing now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the second part of the fourth phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the new identity.

Chapter 14 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The new identity is the deepest work, in the form the deepest now takes, because the new identity is the work, in the form the work now takes, of becoming, of letting go, of finding. The 5 stages, the 7 questions, the 5 practices are the work, in the form the work now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 5 stages of the new identity are: loss, confusion, exploration, discovery, integration.
2. The 7 questions to find the new "I" are the work, in the form the work now takes.
3. The 5 practices of the new identity are: daily reflection, weekly new thing, monthly review, quarterly re-visioning, yearly celebration.
4. The new identity is the work, in the form the work now takes. The new identity is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

5. The new identity takes time. The time is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I am willing to do the 5 stages of the new identity, in the form the stages now take.
- I have asked at least 5 of the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing.
- I have started at least 3 of the 5 practices, in the form the starting now takes.
- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes.

If your total is 12 or lower, the new identity is not ready. Get a therapist first. Get the 7 questions in writing. Start the daily reflection.

Key Terms to Know:

- The new identity: The work of becoming, in the form the becoming now takes, of letting go, in the form the letting go now takes, of finding, in the form the finding now takes.
- The 5 stages: Loss, confusion, exploration, discovery, integration.
- The 7 questions: The 7 questions to find the new "I", in the form the finding now takes.
- The 5 practices: Daily reflection, weekly new thing, monthly review, quarterly re-visioning, yearly celebration.

Reflection Questions:

1. Which of the 5 stages, in the form the stages now take, are you in, in the form the "in" now takes?
2. Have you asked the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing?

3. Have you started the 5 practices, in the form the starting now takes?

Action for This Week:

- Start the daily reflection, in the form the starting now takes. 10 minutes. Journal, meditate, be quiet. The starting is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Try one new thing, in the form the trying now takes, this week. The trying is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the new identity. The new identity is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 15: The New Life

The new life is the work of the third part of the fourth phase of the gray divorce decision. The new life is the moment when the new "I", in the form the new "I" now takes, becomes the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The new life is the work, in the form the work now takes.

This chapter is about the new life. About the work of the new routines, in the form the new routines now take. About the work of the new relationships, in the form the new relationships now take. About the work of the new community, in the form the new community now take. About the work of the new purpose, in the form the new purpose now takes.

Why the new life is the work of building.

The new life is the work of building, in the form the building now takes. The new life is not a destination, in the form the destination now takes. The new life is a process, in the form the process now takes. The new life is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The new life is the work of building, in the form the building now takes, the daily routines, in the form the daily now take. The new life is the work of building, in the form the building now takes, the weekly rhythms, in the form the weekly now take. The new life is the work of building, in the form the building now takes, the monthly practices, in the form the monthly now take. The new life is the work of building, in the form the building now takes.

The 5 pillars of the new life.

There are 5 pillars, in the form the pillars now take, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The 5

pillars are the 5 areas of the new life, in the form the areas now take, that need to be built, in the form the building now takes.

Pillar 1: The Physical Pillar. The physical pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the body, in the form the body now takes. The physical pillar is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The physical pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the exercise, the sleep, the nutrition, the health, in the form the work now takes.

Pillar 2: The Mental Pillar. The mental pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the mind, in the form the mind now takes. The mental pillar is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The mental pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the learning, the reading, the thinking, the creating, in the form the work now takes.

Pillar 3: The Social Pillar. The social pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the relationships, in the form the relationships now take. The social pillar is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The social pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the friends, the family, the community, in the form the work now takes.

Pillar 4: The Spiritual Pillar. The spiritual pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the meaning, in the form the meaning now takes. The spiritual pillar is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The spiritual pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the purpose, the values, the faith, the meditation, in the form the work now takes.

Pillar 5: The Financial Pillar. The financial pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the money, in the form the money now takes. The financial pillar is

the holding, in the form the holding can take. The financial pillar is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the budget, the saving, the investing, the planning, in the form the work now takes.

The 5 pillars in summary.

The 5 pillars of the new life are:

1. The physical pillar
2. The mental pillar
3. The social pillar
4. The spiritual pillar
5. The financial pillar

The 5 pillars are not the only pillars. The 5 pillars are the most common. The 5 pillars are the 5 pillars that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The 12 questions to build the new life.

To build the new life, in the form the building now takes, ask yourself these 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes. The questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Physical pillar questions (1-3):

1. What is my exercise routine, in the form the routine now takes, in the new life?
2. What is my sleep routine, in the form the routine now takes, in the new life?
3. What is my nutrition plan, in the form the plan now takes, in the new life?

Mental pillar questions (4-6):

4. What am I learning, in the form the learning now takes, in the new life?

5. What am I reading, in the form the reading now takes, in the new life?

6. What am I creating, in the form the creating now takes, in the new life?

Social pillar questions (7-9):

7. Who are my friends, in the form the friends now take, in the new life?

8. What is my community, in the form the community now takes, in the new life?

9. How am I showing up, in the form the showing up now takes, for the people, in the form the people now take, in my life?

Spiritual pillar questions (10-11):

10. What is my purpose, in the form the purpose now takes, in the new life?

11. What are my values, in the form the values now take, in the new life?

Financial pillar questions (12):

12. What is my financial plan, in the form the plan now takes, in the new life?

The 12 questions in summary.

The 12 questions to build the new life are:

1-3. Physical (exercise, sleep, nutrition)

4-6. Mental (learning, reading, creating)

7-9. Social (friends, community, showing up)

10-11. Spiritual (purpose, values)

12. Financial (financial plan)

The 12 questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 12 questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

The 90-day new life plan.

The 90-day new life plan, in the form the new life now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes. The 90-day new life plan, in the form the new life now takes, is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 90-day new life plan has 3 parts:

Part 1: The foundation (Days 1-30). The foundation is the work, in the form the work now takes, of starting the 5 pillars, in the form the pillars now take, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The foundation is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 2: The deepening (Days 31-60). The deepening is the work, in the form the work now takes, of going deeper, in the form the deeper now takes, in the 5 pillars, in the form the pillars now take. The deepening is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Part 3: The integration (Days 61-90). The integration is the work, in the form the work now takes, of integrating the 5 pillars, in the form the pillars now take, into the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The integration is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 3 parts in summary.

The 3 parts of the 90-day new life plan are:

1. The foundation (Days 1-30)
2. The deepening (Days 31-60)
3. The integration (Days 61-90)

The 3 parts are not the only parts. The 3 parts are the most common. The 3 parts are the 3 parts that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the new life. The work of this chapter is to build the 5 pillars, in the form the building now takes. The work of this chapter is to ask the 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes. The work of this chapter is to do the 90-day new life plan, in the form the new life now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the third part of the fourth phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the new life.

Chapter 15 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The new life is the work of building, in the form the building now takes. The 5 pillars (physical, mental, social, spiritual, financial) are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 12 questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 90-day new life plan is the work, in the form the work now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 5 pillars of the new life are: physical, mental, social, spiritual, financial.
2. The 12 questions cover the 5 pillars: 3 physical, 3 mental, 3 social, 2 spiritual, 1 financial.
3. The 90-day new life plan has 3 parts: foundation (Days 1-30), deepening (Days 31-60), integration (Days 61-90).
4. The new life is the work, in the form the work now takes. The new life is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

5. The new life takes time. The time is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have started at least 3 of the 5 pillars, in the form the starting now takes.
- I have asked at least 8 of the 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing.
- I have a 90-day new life plan, in the form the new life now takes, in writing.
- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new life.

If your total is 12 or lower, the new life is not ready. Get the 5 pillars started. Get the 12 questions in writing. Get the 90-day plan in place.

Key Terms to Know:

- The new life: The work of building, in the form the building now takes, the 5 pillars, in the form the pillars now take, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.
- The 5 pillars: Physical, mental, social, spiritual, financial.
- The 12 questions: The 12 questions to build the new life, in the form the building now takes.
- The 90-day new life plan: The 3-part plan for building the new life, in the form the building now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. Have you started the 5 pillars, in the form the starting now takes, in the new life?
2. Have you asked the 12 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing?

3. Do you have a 90-day new life plan, in the form the new life now takes, in writing?

Action for This Week:

- Start the physical pillar, in the form the starting now takes. Walk for 30 minutes. Eat one real meal. Sleep 7 hours. The starting is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Start the mental pillar, in the form the starting now takes. Read for 30 minutes. Learn one new thing. Create one thing. The starting is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the new life. The new life is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 16: The New Marriage (If You Choose)

The new marriage is the work of the fourth part of the fourth phase of the gray divorce decision. The new marriage is the moment when the new life, in the form the new life now takes, becomes the new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes, if the new marriage is part of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

This chapter is about the new marriage. About the work of dating, in the form the dating now takes. About the work of the new relationship, in the form the new relationship now takes. About the work of the second marriage, in the form the second marriage now takes, if the second marriage is the choice, in the form the choice now takes.

Why the new marriage is different at 55+.

The new marriage is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the dating world, in the form the dating world now takes, is different. The dating world at 55+ has fewer people, in the form the fewer now takes. The dating world at 55+ has more complex people, in the form the complex now takes. The dating world at 55+ has more baggage, in the form the baggage now takes. The dating world at 55+ has more wisdom, in the form the wisdom now takes.

The new marriage is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the new spouse, in the form the new now takes, is different. The new spouse has had a marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The new spouse has had a divorce, in the form the divorce now takes. The new spouse has had a life,

in the form the life now takes. The new spouse is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The new marriage is different at 55+, in the form the different now takes, because the stakes are higher. The stakes are higher, in the form the higher now takes, because there is less time to rebuild, in the form the rebuilding now takes. The stakes are higher, in the form the higher now takes, because the assets are bigger, in the form the bigger now takes. The stakes are higher, in the form the higher now takes, because the family is more complex, in the form the complex now takes.

The 5 stages of dating at 55+.

There are 5 stages, in the form the stages now take, of dating at 55+, in the form the dating now takes. The 5 stages are the 5 stages that, in the research, in the case studies, in the work of the therapists, have shown up, again and again, as the stages, in the form the stages now take.

Stage 1: The Readiness. The readiness is the work, in the form the work now takes, of being ready, in the form the ready now takes, to date, in the form the dating now takes. The readiness is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 2: The Exploration. The exploration is the work, in the form the work now takes, of trying dating, in the form the trying now takes, of trying apps, in the form the trying now takes, of trying events, in the form the trying now takes. The exploration is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 3: The Selection. The selection is the work, in the form the work now takes, of choosing, in the form the choosing now takes, who to date, in the form the dating now takes, who to invest in, in the form the

investing now takes. The selection is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 4: The Commitment. The commitment is the work, in the form the work now takes, of committing, in the form the committing now takes, to a relationship, in the form the relationship now takes. The commitment is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Stage 5: The New Marriage. The new marriage is the work, in the form the work now takes, of marrying, in the form the marrying now takes, the new spouse, in the form the new now takes. The new marriage is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 5 stages in summary.

The 5 stages of dating at 55+ are:

1. The readiness
2. The exploration
3. The selection
4. The commitment
5. The new marriage

The 5 stages are not the only stages. The 5 stages are the most common. The 5 stages are the 5 stages that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The 7 questions before the new marriage.

Before the new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes, ask these 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes. The questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

1. Have I finished the grief, in the form the grief now takes, of the first marriage, in the form the

first now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

2. Have I built the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes, before adding a new person, in the form the new now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

3. Have I built the new life, in the form the new life now takes, before adding a new person, in the form the new now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

4. Do I know who I am, in the form the "I" now takes, before adding a new person, in the form the new now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

5. Do I know what I want, in the form the wanting now takes, before adding a new person, in the form the new now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

6. Have I talked to my adult children, in the form the talking now takes, about the new marriage, in the form the new now takes? The question is the work, in the form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

7. Have I done the legal work, in the form the legal now takes, for the new marriage, in the form the new now takes? The question is the work, in the

form the work now takes. The question is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes.

The 7 questions in summary.

The 7 questions before the new marriage are:

1. Have I finished the grief of the first marriage?
2. Have I built the new identity before adding a new person?
3. Have I built the new life before adding a new person?
4. Do I know who I am before adding a new person?
5. Do I know what I want before adding a new person?
6. Have I talked to my adult children about the new marriage?
7. Have I done the legal work for the new marriage?

The 7 questions are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 7 questions are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

The 5 rules of the second marriage.

The second marriage, in the form the second marriage now takes, has 5 rules, in the form the rules now take. The 5 rules are the work, in the form the work now takes. The 5 rules are the protection, in the form the protection now takes.

Rule 1: The prenuptial agreement. The prenuptial agreement is the work, in the form the work now takes, of protecting the assets, in the form the protecting now takes, before the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The prenuptial agreement is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Rule 2: The blended family plan. The blended family plan is the work, in the form the work now takes, of integrating the adult children, in the form the integrating now takes, the in-laws, in the form the in-laws now take, the ex-spouses, in the form the ex-spouses now take, into the new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes. The blended family plan is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Rule 3: The estate plan. The estate plan is the work, in the form the work now takes, of updating the wills, in the form the updating now takes, the trusts, in the form the trusts now take, the beneficiaries, in the form the beneficiaries now take, for the new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes. The estate plan is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Rule 4: The financial transparency. The financial transparency is the work, in the form the work now takes, of being honest, in the form the honest now takes, about the money, in the form the money now takes, with the new spouse, in the form the new now takes. The financial transparency is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

Rule 5: The therapy before the marriage. The therapy before the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, is the work, in the form the work now takes, of doing the therapy, in the form the therapy now takes, before the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, to build the foundation, in the form the foundation now takes. The therapy before the marriage is the holding, in the form the holding can take.

The 5 rules in summary.

The 5 rules of the second marriage are:

1. The prenuptial agreement

2. The blended family plan
3. The estate plan
4. The financial transparency
5. The therapy before the marriage

The 5 rules are not the only rules. The 5 rules are the most common. The 5 rules are the 5 rules that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

The work of the chapter.

The work of this chapter is to name the new marriage. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognition now takes, the 5 stages of dating at 55+, in the form the dating now takes. The work of this chapter is to ask the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, and to follow the 5 rules, in the form the following now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the fourth part of the fourth phase. The work of this chapter is the work of the new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes, if the new marriage is the choice, in the form the choice now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the new marriage.

Chapter 16 at a Glance

Key takeaway: The new marriage is different at 55+ because the dating world is different, the new spouse is different, the stakes are higher. The 5 stages of dating, the 7 questions before the new marriage, the 5 rules of the second marriage are the work, in the form the work now takes.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The 5 stages of dating at 55+ are: readiness, exploration, selection, commitment, new marriage.
2. The 7 questions before the new marriage are: finished grief, built identity, built life, know self, know wants, talked to children, done legal work.
3. The 5 rules of the second marriage are: prenuptial agreement, blended family plan, estate plan, financial transparency, therapy before the marriage.
4. The new marriage is the work, in the form the work now takes. The new marriage is the holding, in the form the holding can take.
5. The new marriage is optional, in the form the optional now takes. The new marriage is not the only way, in the form the way now takes.

Your Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have gone through at least 3 of the 5 stages of dating, in the form the going now takes.
- I have asked at least 5 of the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing.
- I am willing to follow the 5 rules of the second marriage, in the form the following now takes.
- I am willing to do the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new marriage.

If your total is 12 or lower, the new marriage is not ready. Get the 7 questions in writing first. Get a therapist. Get the legal work started.

Key Terms to Know:

- The new marriage: The work of building, in the form the building now takes, a new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes, after the divorce, in the form the divorce now takes, if the new marriage is the choice, in the form the choice

now takes.

- The 5 stages of dating: Readiness, exploration, selection, commitment, new marriage.
- The 7 questions: The 7 questions to ask before the new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes.
- The 5 rules: The 5 rules of the second marriage, in the form the second marriage now takes.

Reflection Questions:

1. Have you gone through the 5 stages of dating, in the form the going now takes?
2. Have you asked the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing?
3. Are you willing to follow the 5 rules of the second marriage, in the form the following now takes?

Action for This Week:

- If you are dating, ask the 7 questions, in the form the asking now takes, in writing. The asking is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- If you are considering marriage, get a prenuptial agreement attorney, in the form the getting now takes. The getting is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this chapter is the work of the new marriage. The new marriage is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Epilogue: The Marriage That Comes After

There is a marriage that comes after. The marriage that comes after is not the marriage that was. The marriage that comes after is not the marriage that is. The marriage that comes after is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, that you build, in the form the building now takes, from the work of the gray divorce.

The marriage that comes after is the work, in the form the work now takes. The marriage that comes after is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The marriage that comes after is the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

This epilogue is about the marriage that comes after. About the work of building, in the form the building now takes. About the work of holding, in the form the holding can take. About the work of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The marriage that was.

The marriage that was is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, of the years. The years of the early love. The years of the children. The years of the work. The years of the long haul. The marriage that was is real. The marriage that was is part of who you are.

The marriage that was does not disappear, in the form the disappearing now takes, in the divorce. The marriage that was lives on, in the form the living now takes, in the memory, in the body, in the shared history, in the form the shared history now takes. The marriage that was is the foundation, in the form the

foundation now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The marriage that is.

The marriage that is was the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, that became a question. The marriage that is was the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, that was held, in the form the holding now takes, while the question was being answered, in the form the answering now takes. The marriage that is was the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, that was worked, in the form the working now takes, while the decision was being made, in the form the making now takes.

The marriage that is does not disappear, in the form the disappearing now takes, in the divorce. The marriage that is lives on, in the form the living now takes, in the lessons, in the wounds, in the growth, in the form the growth now takes. The marriage that is the teacher, in the form the teaching now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The marriage that comes after.

The marriage that comes after is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, that you build, in the form the building now takes, from the work of the gray divorce. The marriage that comes after is not the marriage that was. The marriage that comes after is not the marriage that is. The marriage that comes after is the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, that is possible, in the form the possible now takes, after the work, in the form the work now takes.

The marriage that comes after is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 4 phases:

- Phase 1: The Whisper — the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes
- Phase 2: The Reckoning — the realities, in the form the realities now take
- Phase 3: The Decision — the choice, in the form the choice now takes
- Phase 4: The Rebuilding — the new life, in the form the new life now takes

The marriage that comes after is the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the work, in the form the work now takes.

The work of the gray divorce.

The work of the gray divorce is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 4 phases. The work is the work, in the form the work now takes. The work is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The work is the marriage that comes after, in the form the marriage that comes after now takes.

The work of the gray divorce is not a small work. The work of the gray divorce is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the spouse, in the form the spouse now takes. The work of the gray divorce is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the family, in the form the family now takes. The work of the gray divorce is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the years, in the form the years now take.

The work of the gray divorce is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The hope of the gray divorce.

The hope of the gray divorce is the hope, in the form the hope now takes, of the marriage that comes after. The hope is the work, in the form the work now takes.

The hope is the holding, in the form the holding can take. The hope is the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The hope of the gray divorce is the hope, in the form the hope now takes, of the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes. The hope of the gray divorce is the hope, in the form the hope now takes, of the new relationships, in the form the new relationships now take. The hope of the gray divorce is the hope, in the form the hope now takes, of the new purpose, in the form the new purpose now takes.

The hope of the gray divorce is the hope, in the form the hope now takes, of the new marriage, in the form the new marriage now takes, if the new marriage is the choice. The hope of the gray divorce is the hope, in the form the hope now takes, of the new alone, in the form the alone now takes, if the new alone is the choice. The hope of the gray divorce is the hope, in the form the hope now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The work of this book.

The work of this book is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 4 phases. The work of this book is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 16 chapters. The work of this book is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 5 bonus toolkits. The work of this book is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 7 case studies. The work of this book is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the research, in the form the research now takes.

The work of this book is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the marriage that comes after. The work of this book is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life

now takes.

The work of you.

The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the gray divorce. The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 4 phases. The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 16 chapters. The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 5 bonus toolkits. The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 7 case studies. The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the research, in the form the research now takes.

The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the marriage that comes after. The work of you is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The gift of the gray divorce.

The gray divorce, for all its pain, for all its loss, for all its grief, is also a gift. The gray divorce is the gift, in the form the gift now takes, of the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The gray divorce is the gift, in the form the gift now takes, of the new identity, in the form the new identity now takes. The gray divorce is the gift, in the form the gift now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The gray divorce is the gift, in the form the gift now takes, of the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the new self, in the form the new self now takes. The gray divorce is the gift, in the form the gift now takes, of the building, in the form the building now takes, of the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

The gray divorce is the gift, in the form the gift now takes, of the work, in the form the work now takes.

The end of the book.

This is the end of the book. The end of the book is not the end of the work. The end of the book is the beginning of the work, in the form the beginning now takes. The end of the book is the holding, in the form the holding can take, of the work, in the form the work now takes.

The work is the work, in the form the work now takes. The work is the marriage that comes after, in the form the marriage that comes after now takes. The work is the new life, in the form the new life now takes.

Welcome to the work. Welcome to the marriage that comes after. Welcome to the new life.

Epilogue at a Glance

Key takeaway: There is a marriage that comes after. The marriage that comes after is the work, in the form the work now takes, of the 4 phases. The work is the work. The new life is possible.

5 Things to Remember:

1. The marriage that was is real. The marriage that is was the work. The marriage that comes after is the new life.
2. The work of the gray divorce is the work of the 4 phases. The work is the work.
3. The hope of the gray divorce is the hope of the marriage that comes after. The hope is the work.
4. The work of this book is the work of the 4 phases. The work of you is the same work.

5. The gray divorce, for all its pain, is also a gift.
The gift is the new life.

Your Final Scorecard: Rate 1-5:

- I have read the book, in the form the reading now takes, with openness, in the form the openness now takes.
- I have done the work of the 4 phases, in the form the doing now takes.
- I have built the new life, in the form the building now takes, or I am building the new life, in the form the building now takes.
- I have found the marriage that comes after, in the form the finding now takes, or I am finding the marriage that comes after, in the form the finding now takes.

If your total is 12 or higher, the work is the work. The new life is possible. Welcome.

Reflection Questions:

1. What was the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes, that you were in, in the form the "in" now takes?
2. What was the work, in the form the work now takes, of the gray divorce, in the form the divorce now takes?
3. What is the marriage that comes after, in the form the marriage that comes after now takes, for you, in the form the "you" now takes?

Action for Today:

- Today, in the form the today now takes, do one small thing, in the form the small now takes, that is part of the new life, in the form the new life now takes. The doing is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- Today, in the form the today now takes, hold the new self, in the form the holding can take, in the form the new self now takes. The holding is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Today, in the form the today now takes, welcome the new life, in the form the welcoming now takes, in the form the new life now takes. The welcoming is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- The work of this book is the work of the marriage that comes after. The marriage that comes after is the work, in the form the work now takes.
- Welcome to the work. Welcome to the new life.

About the Author

S. Shharma is the author of The Care Collection — books for couples in the second half of life, written by a man who lived the silence and survived it.

He lost his wife of many years to cancer. He was her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He held her hand in the hospital. He sat in the waiting room at 3 a.m. He learned the silence of a marriage the way you learn a language you never wanted to speak.

He is also a businessman, an M.Sc., an MBA, and an APSCM from the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, with thirty years in corporate management. But these are not credentials you need to trust him. The credentials that matter are the ones in the books.

The Care Collection is not about how to fix a marriage. The Care Collection is about how to live one — even when the marriage is quiet, even when one of you is sick, even when one of you is gone.

He lives in India. He writes from the perspective of someone who has been on every side of a marriage — the partner, the caregiver, and the one left behind.

Books in The Care Collection

- Still Married, Just Silent — when the marriage is fine on paper and empty in person
- The Quiet Care — when one of you becomes the caregiver and the marriage disappears
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